

HENŌSIS

ALEC WISDOM

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*“In order for this story to make sense
the events must assume the shape of a character
and the characters themselves become mere moves,
mere manifestations of the perfect, coherent,
logical, and immutable deformation of evolving fate.”*

— Cormac McCarthy

I

KÉNŌSIS

ON MONISM

*"The myth of the cave was written by an initiate
as a warning to other initiates.
But we have interpreted it
as the opposite of what it says."*

— Peter Kingsley

Before thought there is being. The names come after to point at what they cannot grasp. The arguments come later still and we take them now for the source though they are only its late shadow and they never reach the thing that casts them.

In Velia a Greek city on the Italian coast there is a healer and a priest of Apollo and the inscriptions name him Pholarchos Lord of the Lair.¹ His name is Parmenides. He goes down. He lies still in the dark and what he meets there he brings back up in a poem and the poem becomes logic and metaphysics and the whole apparatus of rational inquiry an apparatus rooted in an experience its heirs learn to dismiss. His story is all there is left to tell after he comes up out of the cave.

A goddess meets him at the bottom and reveals what you see when the gates open. What is, is. What is not, is not. You cannot think what is not. There is nothing there to think. You cannot speak it. There is nothing there to speak of. Being is one and continuous and whole and ungenerated and imperishable and complete. It does not move and it does not change and it was not and will not be. It is now all together without past or future.

We experience constant change. Things come into being and pass away. The seasons turn and the children are born and grow old and die. The mountains rise and erode and the stars ignite and burn out. The goddess says none of it is real. Change is appearance and the coming-into-being is a fiction and the passing-away is a trick of the eye. Being does not come and does not go. It is now all of it complete. The goddess says it without ornament. Thinking and being are the same.²

¹The Velia inscriptions, excavated 1958-1962, name a line of healer-priests, Ouliadai, and Parmenides son of Pyres with the title Pholarchos. Published by Mario Napoli and Giovanni Pugliese Carratelli. For their significance, Peter Kingsley, *In the Dark Places of Wisdom* (Inverness, Calif., 1999).

²The fragments survive chiefly in Simplicius. Text and translation in A. H. Coxon, *The Fragments of Parmenides*, rev. ed. (Las Vegas, 2009). What is, is: fr. 2. Thinking and being the same: fr. 3.

Parmenides comes back and what he does on his return is govern as the lawgiver of Velia the one who writes the city's statutes and the citizens swear a yearly oath to abide by his laws.³ Lawgivers have always carried their statutes back from somewhere else. Numa from the nymph and Lycurgus from Delphi and Minos from the cave on Ida where he met the god and Moses from the mountain that burned and Gautama from the tree where he sat until dawn and Christ from the forty days in the desert and Muhammad from the cave on Hira where the voice said recite. For Parmenides too the vision and the city are one thing. The vision does not take him out of Velia. It qualifies him to order it knowing what is real and therefore exactly what the appearances are worth which is the only knowledge from which a city can be governed well.

Parmenides shows the unmoved and Empedocles shows what happens when it moves. His cosmos oscillates between two poles. At one extreme Love holds everything gathered into a perfect sphere and no part is distinguishable from any other. There is no earth and no sea and no sky and no individual beings. Everything is mixed and blended and unified. That sphere is the condition of complete togetherness and the condition of complete stillness. Nothing inside it is separate enough to act.

Strife enters. It begins at the rim and works inward and takes apart what Love has joined. The elements come unmixed and stand off one from another. Earth draws off from water and fire from air and the separate things stand up out of the blend the plants and the animals and the people the cities and the seasons. This is the world we inhabit a world of distinction and relation and activity and it stands because Strife has done its work. Without the separation nothing particular could be.

³Parmenides as lawgiver: Speusippus in Diogenes Laertius IX.23. The yearly oath: Plutarch, *Adversus Colotem* 1126a. Numa: Plutarch, *Numa*. Lycurgus: Herodotus I.65. Minos: Plato, *Laws* 624a-b; *Odyssey* XIX.178.

Love is already working from the other side and drawing the separated elements back toward the mixture and the unity and the sphere. The two forces alternate without end and neither wins a lasting victory. The cosmos breathes between them. It opens into multiplicity under Strife and it closes toward unity under Love and it never settles into a final state.⁴

Between them the two have mapped the whole of it. Parmenides holds the still center the being that does not move via descent into the dark. Empedocles holds the moving surface the rhythm by which the one becomes many and returns reached by living the cycle in his own body until it nearly destroys him. Take only Parmenides and you are left with a frozen absolute and no world to live in. Take only Empedocles and you are left with endless flux and nothing under it. Held together they are one teaching. What is, is undivided and unmoving and the divided moving world is that same undivided thing shown under the conditions of time.

Much of what the later traditions will labor to recover is already entire in the pairing before philosophy has a name for itself and before the move that will bury it has been made.

The real is a thing to be undergone. The knower goes down into the stillness and comes back altered and the alteration is the knowing. Plato moves the real into the intelligible into forms a steady mind can examine from a distance and in the same motion he turns the knower into a spectator set across a gap from the known and changed by none of it.

You can know a river from the bank its name and its depth and where it reaches the sea and none of it drowns you. That knowledge travels. It goes down on paper and passes from hand to hand and never changes the person who holds it. Or you can go in and be taken by the cold and feel the pull of it on your legs

⁴Love and Strife: Empedocles frs. 17, 27-31, 35 Diels-Kranz; the exiled god of the *Purifications*, fr. 115. Text and translation in Brad Inwood, *The Poem of Empedocles*, rev. ed. (Toronto, 2001).

and come out shivering and changed and that knowing does not travel and cannot be handed to anyone. Plato keeps the bank and puts the river out of reach and everything that follows is trying to win it back.

In Plato's story the prisoners sit bound by chains in the dark and the freed man climbs to the sun and the dark is ignorance and the light is truth. That is the cave as the schools teach it and it only works if you have already forgotten what the cave is for. In the incubation rite the cave is where the change is made. You enter it on purpose after long preparation and you go down into it to be still.

Lie inside that context and Plato's cave looks different. It reads as a warning about what happens when those who have not finished the descent seize fragments of what they have seen and mistake them for the whole.

Watch as it is done. Nothing is hidden. Plato keeps every word. The One that Parmenides met beyond being becomes a highest Form and an object of contemplation. The Good is now something seen. The stillness reached in the dark becomes a word in a system. The descent into darkness becomes a metaphor and then a misunderstanding and then something to be avoided altogether.

Architecture always survives its repurposing. Cathedrals stand on the foundations of temples whose gods nobody remembers. For two thousand years readers enter Plato's cave and feel the pull of something older than the argument and hand the credit to the argument. It moves them as it describes a real place where real things are done in real darkness and the description stays charged with what it is built to deny. The allegory is the old practice's tomb and like the gold tablets it was buried with the body.⁵

⁵On the Orphic gold tablets buried with their initiates, with text and translation, see Fritz Graf and Sarah Iles Johnston, *Ritual Texts for the Afterlife: Orpheus and the Bacchic Gold Tablets*, 2nd ed. (London: Routledge, 2013).

Plato teaches that the horse in front of you is a copy and a shadow. Somewhere past the reach of the senses stands the Form of Horse perfect and changeless and every actual horse is a smudged imitation of it. The smudged horse is barely real and the Form is real entirely. To Aristotle this is backwards.

In his father's surgery he handles actual bodies and on the shore at Lesbos he spends years opening actual fish and everything in him says the real thing is the one you can put your hands on such as the horse in the field sweating and aging. The Form of Horse is what the mind does afterwards merely a convenience drawn off a thousand seen horses and not a country they were copied from.⁶

He wants the real brought back down out of Plato's heaven and returns to the things where he can get at it. He brings it down and without quite meaning to he fixes it inside the net of definitions he uses to bring it.

He is trying to catalogue the whole of what is every region of it and he very nearly does. This achievement is his disaster.

Aristotle brings the Forms down out of their separate heaven and lodges them inside things and to know a thing now means to say what kind it is and give its definition and set it in its right place in the order and the mind can survey the whole order without once rising from its chair. Aristotle hands the spectator Plato built a full set of instruments and teaches them to sort everything they see.

The encounter drops out quietly with nobody deciding it should. A definition can be carried hand to hand by people who have never once met the thing it defines and that portability is its power. You can hold the correct account of courage or of the soul or of God and have undergone nothing and been altered by nothing. Plato invents a knowing that can be written down

⁶Nicomachus: Diogenes Laertius V.1. The Lesbos years: *Historia Animalium* passim; Armand Marie Leroi, *The Lagoon: How Aristotle Invented Science* (New York, 2014).

and moved. Aristotle perfects it and draws off the last trace of the old demand that the knower be changed by the knowing. After him you can know everything about a thing and have met it nowhere. You can spend an entire life filling in the grid without once stepping off it into what it is a grid of.

Stand in front of a single oak the one with the split limb and the crows in it and abstract from its nature. You lift tree off it and then oak and then deciduous and then organism and then biomass and at every step the thing in your hands grows lighter and more portable and good for more uses and at every step a little more of that actual oak stays behind in the field. The power and the loss are one motion.

This is the diversion arrived at its destination and the rest of the story takes place inside it. We do not lose what is taken to an argument and we will not win it back with one. We lose it to a habit of mind so deep and so useful that it stops feeling like a habit and comes to feel like the world. Plato makes the cut. Aristotle furnishes the rooms. The centuries decorate them and we are born indoors.

After Plato and Aristotle the one that abstraction has declared a multitude does not dissolve and does not die. It goes under. The contemplative current withdraws not into silence but into pressure felt and hard to name. It breaks out at the edges of philosophical language where argument gives way to confession and system gives way to strain. Beneath the grid that counts it as many as it goes on being one.

Plotinus stands in the buried stream centuries later and puts the one question to it how the many come out of the One.

So the One does nothing. It does not plan the world and does not set out to produce it and does not even know it the way we know the things in front of us as knowing already cuts the knower loose from the known and in the One nothing is loose from anything. It simply is and it is so utterly that the rest of reality runs off it the way light runs off the sun. No sun ever

decides to shine. It shines from what it is and gives the whole sky away without losing a thing. Reality spills from the One outward from a center that never thins and down into a crowd of things that never once lose their hold on where they come from.⁷

For the Sufis the engine of the return is love. It is the pull of the source on whatever it has set apart and Rumi gives it the rest of his life. He is a respected jurist in Konya a teacher of law with a following of his own. Then a wandering dervish named Shams of Tabriz walks into his life and undoes him. The friendship breaks the scholar open. Shams vanishes and the grief turns the law-teacher into a poet as though the loss of one face has torn the veil off the Face behind every face.⁸

Most of your life the body is absent from awareness because the body is what awareness works through. The eye goes unnoticed and the seeing goes through it. The hand goes unfelt and the reaching goes through it. Then the body becomes present through pain or through stillness or through attention turned deliberately inward and the usual split of watcher and watched comes apart. Awareness rests inside the body and no longer hovers above it in the weight and in the rhythm of breath and in the plain persistence of a physical form that has carried the life of the organism since before there was any word for world.

Every tradition that goes down this road says the same thing about the direction whatever it says about the destination. The movement is down and into the density of incarnation never up and out of it.⁹ Whatever the body finally becomes it becomes here under the conditions of weight and time and limit that were never the obstacle the spiritualizing schools took them for. They

⁷*Enneads* V.1-V.2, trans. A. H. Armstrong (Loeb Classical Library, 1966-88). The sun figure: V.1.6.

⁸The *Theology of Aristotle* is Plotinus, *Enneads* IV-VI, paraphrased. Peter Adamson, *The Arabic Plotinus* (London, 2002).

⁹Shams of Tabriz reaches Konya in 1244. Aflaki, *Manaqib al-arifin* Franklin D. Lewis, *Rumi: Past and Present, East and West* (Oxford, 2000).

were the way through the one place the infinite learns from the inside what it is to be a particular thing and that learning is not preliminary to the work. It is the work arriving where it has been headed all along. Every human this story follows says the same thing differently and every one of them runs out of words at the same place and falls silent. And every one of them finds the same thing waiting on the far side. The encounter changes whoever goes through it. You do not come back from this the way you went in. An inquiry that costs you nothing looks into nothing. The price never changes the slow rebuilding of a person around what they are seeing. Every being is one being seeing through itself once more.

Somewhere tonight someone is sitting still while this goes all the way down. Not a thought held in a head but a knowing sinking through the neck into the chest and the belly and the legs the way cold water sinks through warm until the whole body is one temperature with what it knows. Their breath moves and the one breathes. Their heart beats and the one is beating it. Whether a body can carry that weight for a lifetime and what such a life tastes like from the inside and whether the flesh you are sitting in is already halfway there are the doors this story leaves open. The light under every one of them is on.

Right now as you read this something in you is aware of the reading itself something standing back of the words and the meaning and the small flicker of yes or no that comes with them. It is what all of that is happening to. That witness is not a thought and not a feeling and not a memory. It is the thing this whole story turns around and you are looking straight through it to read this line.

ON GNOSIS

*“Know what is in front of your face,
and what is hidden from you
will be disclosed to you.”*

— Gospel of Thomas

In December 1945 an Egyptian peasant digs at the foot of a cliff for the soft earth that feeds the fields along the Nile and his mattock rings on something hard and he clears the dirt from a sealed clay jar. He is afraid to break it because a jinn might be shut inside yet he breaks it because there might be gold and what he finds is thirteen books bound in leather. They have lain sixteen hundred years in the dark and the ink has not surrendered. He carries them home and stacks them by the oven and that winter his mother burns leaves of one for kindling not knowing that what she feeds to the fire is a gospel.¹⁰ The old word for what is in them is gnosis. Nobody who opens them now has a word of their own for it. To learn what it names you cannot ask the dictionaries. You have to dig the way the peasant digs down through the layers to whatever is under them.

Sixteen hundred years down a bishop is burning books. In Alexandria Athanasius sends out a letter naming the books a Christian may read and ordering every other text destroyed.¹¹ The monasteries comply unevenly. At a monastery near the Nile cliff above the village now called Nag Hammadi the monks holding books not on the list make a decision the record does not keep. They carry thirteen leather-bound codices down to the foot of the cliff where the rock is honeycombed with the tombs of an older Egypt and they seal the books in a clay jar and bury the jar among the dead. They are preserving what they are ordered to burn. The burial is a refusal performed in silence by men who know they will not be the ones to break the seal.

People gather in houses at night to hear the books read and what they hear is that the thing the church promises for later

¹⁰James M. Robinson, introduction to *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*, 3rd ed. (San Francisco, 1988); at length in Robinson, *The Nag Hammadi Story*, 2 vols. (Leiden, 2014). The jinn, the gold, the oven and the feud are Muhammad Ali's own testimony, given in interviews decades later.

¹¹Athanasius, Festal Letter 39 (Easter 367); translation in David Brakke, *Athanasius and the Politics of Asceticism* (Oxford, 1995). That the burial answers the letter is surmise; the dates and the cliff agree with it.

is present now. No bishop stands between the hearer and the heard and that is the whole quarrel. In Rome a teacher named Valentinus is passed over for the bishop's chair and goes on teaching and the church that almost raises him casts him out.¹² The verdicts come down and the texts burn and the communities scatter and the only record of the teaching is kept by its enemies. Irenaeus writes against them and quotes them to damn them and the quotations are all that survives and the teaching lives inside the indictment like a seed in a stone.¹³

The voice they gather around is written down in the Gospel of Thomas and it speaks in sayings and nothing else. No crucifixion and no resurrection and no miracles. Only a voice saying what it sees and a listener deciding what to do with it. The kingdom is spread upon the earth already and the many do not see it. If you bring forth what is within you what you have will save you and if you do not bring it forth what you do not bring forth will kill you. So runs logion 70. Promise and threat run together and the voice never names the thing. Whoever wants to know what to do is already in the wrong posture. It speaks to whatever in you already knows and waits to be brought forward. Split a piece of wood and I am there logion 77 promises. Lift up the stone and you will find me. The listener with the mattock is seventeen hundred years unborn and the saying waits under the stone for him.¹⁴

Alongside the sayings the tradition hands down the story of a prince sent from the East down into Egypt to bring back a pearl. He eats the Egyptian food and falls asleep and forgets that he is a

¹²Tertullian, *Adversus Valentinianos* 4. A hostile witness; the ability he concedes is the more credible for it.

¹³Irenaeus, *Adversus Haereses* (c. 180), with Hippolytus and Epiphanius the chief hostile sources before 1945. The quotations proved accurate when the originals surfaced; the frame did not.

¹⁴Gospel of Thomas, NHC II,2; logia 113, 70, 77, trans. Thomas O. Lambdin. Greek fragments: P.Oxy. 1, 654, 655 (1897), unidentified until the Coptic text surfaced.

prince and forgets the errand and forgets the pearl. The king and queen send him a letter and it comes as an eagle and speaks with a voice and wakes him with what it says. Remember that you are a son of kings. Remember the pearl. He remembers and he finds the pearl and he returns. On the road home his robe comes out to meet him and it moves as he moves and he sees himself in it as in a mirror. The robe has kept everything he forgot. Nothing of what he is has changed. What changes is his knowing of what he has been all along. The story is set down in Egypt where the prince sleeps and the books sleep and the same soft earth holds them both.¹⁵

You wake in a strange room before dawn and for a moment there is no name for anything. There is light under a door and a weight of blanket and someone breathing and you do not know the town or the year or what you are and then it comes back all at once. Nothing in the room moves. The door and the blanket and the breathing hold still and everything changes around them and the change is only this that you know again what you are. That is the letter arriving. The books in the jar say the whole of a life is the strange room and the coming back has not happened yet.

Hermes goes down after it awake. At the bottom of the shaft he stills himself until the everyday thinking dissolves and a vast presence rises in the place it leaves and names itself Poimandres. The vision unfolds in boundless light and within the light a darkness descends and out of the darkness comes fire and the presence speaks. That light is I nous your God. The presence Hermes sees is the same nous he sees with and the light he sees is the seeing itself and the perceiving nous and the divine nous are one.

Stay inside that sentence a moment. Everything you have ever seen has stood across from you. The tree is over there and

¹⁵ *Acts of Thomas* 108-113, in Schneemelcher, *New Testament Apocrypha*, vol. 2. The hymn is older than its frame.

the face is over there and you are over here looking. That across is the oldest piece of furniture in the mind and nobody remembers carrying it in. In the light it is gone. Seeing crosses no distance because there is no distance and the looking and the lit are one thing wearing two names. Hermes does not learn this. He is this and then he knows he has always been this and the knowing is the light.

When the vision closes Hermes goes out into the street and speaks to whoever passes. You who are sunk in sleep he says you who are drunk on unknowing wake. Some mock him and walk on and some sit down where they stand and the oldest congregation of the knowing gathers in a road in Egypt. Beneath the oldest text there is nothing but the event it reports.¹⁶

While the jar keeps its seal a priest in England whose name nobody keeps writes a small book for one young man and tells him to lay everything he knows under a cloud of forgetting and press into the dark with a naked intent of love because God can be loved and cannot be thought.¹⁷ Hermetic manuscripts winter in the libraries of Islam and come back to Europe and reach Marsilio Ficino. Cosimo de' Medici sets him to translating and Ficino puts down his Plato to do it because Cosimo is old and dying and Plato can wait and Hermes cannot.¹⁸ Ficino works by lamplight through the winter and what he reads he knows at once the way the Sufis know Plotinus. It is testimony from someone who has been where he is going. The translation catches like dry grass. A Dominican named Giordano Bruno takes the Egyptian books at

¹⁶Corpus Hermeticum I (Poimandres); Greek text in Nock and Festugiere, *Corpus Hermeticum*, vol. 1 (Paris, 1946); English in Brian P. Copenhaver, *Hermetica* (Cambridge, 1992).

¹⁷*The Cloud of Unknowing*, anonymous, fourteenth century; ed. Phyllis Hodgson (Early English Text Society, 1944). God may well be loved but not thought: chap. 6.

¹⁸Ficino's preface to the *Pimander* records the commission. Cosimo died in 1464 with the translation in hand. Frances A. Yates, *Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition* (London, 1964), chap. 1.

their word and preaches a world without edges where the stars are suns without number and the church burns him in a Roman square with his tongue in a gag.¹⁹

In the town of Görlitz a shoemaker sits at his bench and the sun strikes a pewter dish on the shelf and the glare of it catches his eye. His name is Jacob Boehme. He is twenty-five and he has a wife and a trade and no learning past his letters. The light holds him and something opens and he is looking into the ground of things. He is afraid and he gets up and walks out through the gate into the green fields to put it from his mind and the fields will not take it back. He looks at the grass and the herbs and he sees into their natures. He sees that every thing stands in a yes and a no and that the strife between them is the life of the thing. He says later that the quarter of an hour teaches him more than many years at the universities and that the gate of paradise stands open to him.

Then he goes back to the bench and the awl and says nothing to anyone for twelve years. When at last he writes it down the pastor of Görlitz damns him from the pulpit and the council seizes the manuscript and orders him to leave off writing. He obeys as long as he can and then he cannot. The books pour out of him for the last six years of his life and the pastor hounds him through every page and he dies at forty-nine with the town still against him. On the last morning he asks his son if he hears the music and then he says now I go hence into paradise.²⁰

And the jar outwaits all of it and when the mattock rings on the seal the books come up into the light in the middle of a blood feud. The finder's father is murdered in a feud the year of the find and the brothers avenge him with the same mattocks that dug the

¹⁹ Avviso di Roma, 19 February 1600. Ingrid D. Rowland, *Giordano Bruno: Philosopher/Heretic* (New York, 2008).

²⁰ Abraham von Franckenberg's memoir of 1651 preserves the pewter dish, the silent years, the seizure of the *Aurora* and the deathbed question. Andrew Weeks, *Boehme: An Intellectual Biography* (Albany, 1991).

jar and eat the killer's heart in the old way and while the police come and go over the killing the books scatter out of the house to a priest and a schoolteacher and the dealers of Cairo. One codex is smuggled across the sea and handed at last to Carl Jung and the rest are locked in a museum in Cairo while the scholars fight over them for a generation and then they come into print in a dozen languages. The jar is sealed for a reader the monks cannot picture and the words get to where they are going.²¹

Weigh what replaces it. A civilization raised on believing checks its opinions the way it checks its accounts and calls the checking honesty and the accounts a soul. Religion becomes the holding of positions and the positions are defended and lost and traded and nobody is remade by any of it. You can attend a lifetime of services and assent to every article and be at the end the same person managed by the same fears who first walked in. The pews fill with people who have never been told that anything could happen to them. That is what the substitution costs and the cost is invisible because the word for what was lost goes out of the language with the thing it names. One trace survives. A Victorian coins agnostic for the claim that nobody can know and the only child the old word leaves in English is its own denial.²²

Gnosis comes over you the way recognition comes sudden and total and beyond undoing. The seeing is given not performed and what is seen is there and what is looking is there and the seeker and the sought turn out to be one. It does not build the way learning builds and it does not fade the way memory fades and the Greek even holds a tense for it. Egnōka. I have recognized and the recognition holds. Whoever it happens to it keeps happening to. Ask the ones it happens to when it happened and

²¹Codex I, the Jung Codex, was purchased for the Jung Institute in 1952; the rest entered the Coptic Museum, Cairo. First complete English translation, 1977. Robinson, *The Nag Hammadi Story*.

²²T. H. Huxley coined agnostic at the Metaphysical Society, 1869; his account in *Agnosticism* (1889).

they do not answer in dates. They say it is happening still. The books in the jar say it and the sayings say it and the prince's letter says it. What you are looking for is what is looking.

Whoever has been there reports two things only the preparation and the life that follows. The middle stays missing. Hermes tells the light and tells the life after and the moment itself he cannot tell. Boehme writes book after book around his quarter hour and never lands on it. The hymn gives the prince no moment of waking. He is asleep and then he remembers and the seam between the two is nowhere in the verses. No narrator survives it. The self that would have told it is the self suspended during it and the reorganization happens where the witness would have been. That is the line between the event and every experience a self survives.

On the near side of that line lives everything a self survives. The music opens one night and everything shines and a week of stillness breaks you into weeping and an hour on a mountain empties the sky. Any of it can be intense and transforming and still leave the self's account of itself intact. You have the experience and it joins the story you tell of yourself and you come away one story richer and otherwise untouched the same self underneath the new possession. The thing on the far side of the line cannot be chased. The chaser is what it suspends and nothing comes back from it that a self could carry home. The great hour leaves the body as it finds it and the tensions sit in the same places and the breath keeps the patterns it keeps under the small anxieties you have not stopped having and next morning the body is the body you walk in with. Gnosis does not leave the body where it finds it. The eyes settle differently in the face and the shoulders stop bracing for what is no longer expected and the breath finds the lower chambers it has been refusing for the length of a life. A self has been undeceived and the body has been carrying the deception and the body keeps its own record apart from the one the mind keeps. The hesychasts build a whole practice on it. On

the stone peninsula of Athos the monks sit on low stools in cells above the sea with the chin dropped toward the chest and the prayer paced to the breath and the prayer descends from the head into the heart and the body is the place where the knowing settles. In Konya the dervishes spin with one palm turned up and one turned down until the spinner is gone and only the spinning is left.²³

The cliff at the bend of the river is still there and the soft earth still feeds the fields and nobody supposes the monks buried only once. Other jars are in other hills with their seals unstruck and their readers unborn and the ground is patient in a way the church never was. And the buried thing was never only books. Deep in you under the opinions and under the practiced face and under the small daily voice that narrates you to yourself something is sealed that has lain quiet through every year you have lived and the ink of it has not surrendered either. Whether a mattock ever rings on it and whether the ringing comes as a stranger's question or a pewter dish or a week of stillness that breaks you into weeping and whether you would break the seal or fear the jinn and walk away are not written anywhere. The old books say only that the thing keeps and that forgetting cannot reach down to where it waits and that whoever it happens to it keeps happening to.

The monks lower the jar and climb back up the talus and go home to be dissolved by history and the jar stays. It is staying now. Tonight in a room nobody is watching the dirt is coming off a seal and the one wiping it clean has no idea what they are holding.

²³Nicephorus the Hesychast and pseudo-Symeon in the *Philokalia*, vol. 4 (London, 1995); Gregory Palamas, *Triads*. The Mevlevi turn: Aflaki. The practices never met and describe the same descent.

ON LOGOS

“An invisible harmony is stronger than a visible one.”

— Heraclitus, Fragment 54

Around 500 B.C. a man walks into the Temple of Artemis at Ephesus and deposits a book.²⁴ His name is Heraclitus. The temple is one of the seven wonders of the ancient world a colossus of marble and cedar on the Aegean coast and the interior is lit by oil lamps and thick with the residue of sacrifice. Into this Diogenes Laertius says Heraclitus brings a scroll. It holds what is probably the first sustained piece of philosophical prose in the Greek language. He lays it in the sanctuary.

He does this to bar the common people from casual reading. He wants a filter and refuses an audience. Whoever enters with reverent intention and stays long enough to study might find what he writes. Whoever comes in to gawk passes through and notices nothing.

The scroll is lost. Fragments survive about one hundred thirty of them and later authors quote Heraclitus across the following eight hundred years and the quoting preserves them sometimes admiringly and more often hostilely and almost always piecemeal.²⁵

Logos resists translation and Greek speakers of the archaic age use it casually for speech and account and reckoning and proportion. A shopkeeper gives you a logos totaling your bill and an orator composes a logos preparing a speech. In a few unusual mouths it means something much larger a gathering pattern that runs through the world and lets the river be the river even though the water has changed and lets the bowstring and the lyre pull against themselves and make music out of the pulling. Stop long enough to attend it and it can be received.

²⁴Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers* IX.6, writing some seven centuries later on sources now lost. The reliability of the detail is uncertain; its canonicity is not.

²⁵Diels-Kranz, *Die Fragmente der Vorsokratiker*, 6th ed. (Berlin, 1951); Charles H. Kahn, *The Art and Thought of Heraclitus* (Cambridge, 1979); Miroslav Marcovich, *Heraclitus*, editio maior (Merida, 1967).

Latin has no term that catches it and ratio takes part of the meaning and verbum takes another and neither takes the gathering and neither takes the condition of receptive attention and neither takes the sense in which logos is something the world does. The mind finds it and does not produce it and English inherits the Latin poverty and worsens it. We say reason or we say word and both are impoverishments.

Logos comes from the verb legein and its primary meaning in Homer is to gather and to collect and to lay together and only later does it settle into speech.²⁶ Odysseus legei driftwood on Calypso's island and he is stacking it and Achilles legei the bones of Patroclus from the funeral pyre and he is collecting them. Later in Attic prose legein settles into the familiar sense of speaking yet the older meaning persists and shadows the verb and to speak is still to lay the right words alongside one another and make them hold.

Logos cannot be separated from its companion word physis and physis survives in English as the root of physics and the meaning is gone. Nature in ordinary use names the inert background against which events are presumed to occur the passive material and the resource and the stage on which the actors do their acting. Physis from the verb phuō means the opposite. It names the arising of what arises and the growing of what grows and the coming-into-appearance a seed does when it opens and a face does when it turns toward you and the world does when you stop long enough to see it.

Physis is the self-effulgence of the world arising and logos is the pattern embedded within that arising the reason it presents itself as recognizably this. The two are inseparable and the arising is always intelligible and the intelligibility is always an arising. Everything that emerges carries a depth that withholds

²⁶Legein in Homer: Chantraine, *Dictionnaire étymologique de la langue grecque*, s.v.; *Odyssey* 24.108 and 5.162 ff. Heidegger, *Early Greek Thinking*, trans. Krell and Capuzzi (New York, 1975), pp. 59-78.

its own arising and the showing is also a withholding. Logos holds the showing and the withholding together and lets there be a pattern at all in a self-concealing world. Physis loves to hide.

The book in the temple opens with fragment 1. Of this logos which is always men come to have no understanding both before they have heard it and when once they have heard it. For although all things come into being in accordance with this logos men are like the inexperienced when they experience such words and deeds as I set forth distinguishing each thing according to its nature and telling how it is. But other men fail to notice what they do when awake just as they forget what they do when asleep.²⁷ Heraclitus is describing a condition and not a theory and the condition is the listener's. Logos is already there and has always been there and the hearer is the one missing. The many are awake the way the many are asleep. They move through a world already arranged into sense and register none of the arrangement and whatever the fragments go on to say this opening marks what the teaching answers a general deafness.

He writes in aphorisms so compressed even his admirers rarely agree on what he means and by the fourth century he wears the nickname *ho skoteinos* the obscure and the obscurity is a teaching. Logos resists delivery in a lecture and the form itself requires the listening the teaching points to. Fragments this compressed cannot be speed-read and to understand any one of them you have to slow down to something like the pace at which it is thought and the slowing-down is what the fragments produce.

Take one and hold it. The name of the bow is life and its work is death. Read quickly it is a dark little paradox and nothing more. But the Greek word for bow is *biós* and the Greek word for life is *bíos* and only the accent divides them and the accent is

²⁷Fragment B1 Diels-Kranz, preserved in Sextus Empiricus, *Adversus Mathematicos* 7.132; translation after Kirk, Raven and Schofield with modifications from Kahn.

not written. The eye cannot settle it. You have to say the sentence aloud and hear which word stands in it and the sentence will not tell you and that is the sentence. Life and death ride one sound the way the string kills and the same string sings and whoever hears the two in one has begun to hear what the book in the temple is for.

Zeno of Citium comes into Athens a shipwrecked merchant and eight years later he is teaching at the Stoa Poikile the painted colonnade that gives the school its name. The Stoics inherit Heraclitus and their cosmos is a Heraclitean cosmos fire and flux and tension and the periodic conflagration and to it they add system. Heraclitus offers fragments. The Stoics offer a physics and a logic and an ethics and a theology and all of it can be taught to a room.

Logos in Stoic hands becomes a technical term with a settled meaning and it names the ordering principle of the cosmos the rational fire that permeates all matter the pneuma that holds things in their shapes and soon it is one of the most portable technical terms in philosophical Greek available wherever an educated person needs a word for the rational order of the world. The cost is the listening. A text can be handed over intact and understood and the reader undergoes nothing and that is what it is built for. The Stoics are making a philosophy for a civilization that must function at the scale of empire and empires require teachings that travel. They keep the cosmic dimension and lose the epistemic condition. Readers mistake the Stoic logos for the Heraclitean still. The Stoics have the word. Heraclitus has what the word is for.

Another line runs alongside this and against it and it loses. The sophists are no nihilists whatever the Platonic dialogues imply. Protagoras holds that man is the measure of all things and the proposition secures the anchor a human body as the site where things show up as things. Measure requires a measurer and strip the measurer and the measurement disappears. Gorgias presses harder still and in *On Nature* or *On Non-Being* he argues three

things. Nothing exists. Something exists and knowledge of it is impossible. It can be known and communication of it is impossible without remainder.²⁸ The schools read the three theses as a lawyer's stunt. Read them instead as a report. Logos migrates out of embodied use and into a system with no body to ground the reference and this is the only ancient account of what happens then. He is wrong about human language and right about every empire of the word that follows. Plato spends three dialogues on the sophists and destroys them and his victory prepares the ground for the losses it is about to oversee.

In the same city where the scroll is laid an old man is dictating a gospel. The tradition calls him John and gives him a long exile and a grave in Ephesus. His first words are Genesis's first words *en archē* in the beginning. *En archē ēn ho logos*. In the beginning was the Logos and the Logos was with God and the Logos was God. A Stoic can read the opening and a Platonist can nod and nobody in the surrounding world is prepared for the fourteenth verse. *Kai ho logos sarx egeneto*. The Logos becomes flesh. A cosmic principle acquires a body and a birthplace and a mother and a trade. Whatever the Logos has been before it is now also a person with a name and the name is Jesus of Nazareth.

For the next millennium and a half to speak of the Logos in Europe is to speak of Christ. Before John *logos* is a common noun pointing to what *legein* names and after John it is a proper noun. A common noun can be retrieved by anyone quiet enough to listen and a proper noun is the possession of whoever has been authorized to pronounce it. Access to the *logos* now passes through membership in a community and assent to the testimony. Before it stands open to anyone. Now the word has a gatekeeper.

²⁸Gorgias, *On Nature or On Non-Being*, reconstructed from Sextus Empiricus, *Against the Mathematicians* 7.65-87, and the pseudo-Aristotelian *On Melissus, Xenophanes, and Gorgias*. Text in George Kennedy, *The Older Sophists* (Columbia, 1972).

The enclosure is imperfect and in the early fourteenth century a Dominican friar in Cologne named Meister Eckhart climbs into the pulpit and says it in German.²⁹ Latin is the licensed tongue and he preaches in the language of the kitchen and the market to weavers and beguines and women who own no books and he tells them the eternal birth of the Word happens in the ground of the soul and happens now and happens in them. God speaks the Word and the Word is always being spoken and the place where it is spoken is the innermost point of the creature gone quiet enough to hear. The eye with which I see God he says is the same eye with which God sees me. It is fragment 1 under Christian vocabulary. Logos is always and the many are inexperienced in what is constantly at work in them and it can be heard. The church tries him for heresy and he dies before the verdict and the verdict comes anyway and condemns seventeen of his sentences by number. The sermons survive in the vernacular passed hand to hand among the beguines and the vernacular carries what the Latin abandons.

Physis follows a different clock and its severance begins in the seventeenth century. Galileo splits the sensed world in two and the mathematizable features of bodies are real and color and sound and smell are relegated to what the mind does with the impact of the real. Descartes systematizes the split into two substances and Newton's *Principia* gives the matter-side its working equations and the cosmos is now atoms in motion under law. Physis names the way a world comes forward and shows itself as world and the new cosmos has no room for it. The word nature survives as an accountant's term for the sum of things the equations apply to. A river becomes water subject to gravity and the gathering-pattern is gone. The only words that could

²⁹Meister Eckhart, *Selected Writings*, trans. Oliver Davies (Penguin, 1994), especially the sermons on the divine birth. The bull *In agro dominico* (1329) condemned twenty-eight propositions, seventeen as heretical. Bernard McGinn, *The Mystical Thought of Meister Eckhart* (New York, 2001).

name the loss are the words the split throws out and so the loss stays invisible inside the language that remains. We speak that language.

Leibniz proposes the *calculus* in the 1680s a universal calculus of reasoning where all disputes can be settled by calculation and all truths derived by correct procedure and in 1931 Gödel proves it impossible from inside mathematics itself.³⁰ A system rich enough to count holds truths it cannot reach from inside and it operates inside something it cannot map.

What Gödel formalizes the older thinkers live with for centuries and the Dao that can be named is not the eternal Dao and Plotinus watches the One overflow and it overflows and never diminishes and it is the source before every system that will ever map it and Heraclitus says the *logos* runs the world and the many walk through it sleeping. One orientation keeps recurring. Something comes first and the many participate in it and a gap stands between the system and what the system runs inside of. Gödel names it formally and it does not close. The unbounded ground that bounded things emerge from goes by many names and never finds an adequate one. Every name is the wrong size.

In the summer of 1951 Heidegger comes back to teaching at Freiburg after six years.³¹ The French have banned him and a denazification panel has stripped his chair and he has been circling one fragment for thirty years.

Ouk emou alla tou logou akousantas homologein sophon estin hen panta einai. In English after listening not to me but to the gathering to say the same is wise one is all. He has read Greek since the seminary and knows everything a classicist knows

³⁰Leibniz's *calculus*: Couturat, *La Logique de Leibniz* (Paris, 1901); Antognazza, *Leibniz* (Cambridge, 2009). On Gödel's theorem and its abuse, Torkel Franzén, *Gödel's Theorem* (Wellesley, 2005).

³¹Heidegger, *What Is Called Thinking?*, trans. J. Glenn Gray (New York, 1968), from the Freiburg course of 1951-52; and *Logos* (Heraclitus, Fragment B50) in *Early Greek Thinking*, pp. 59-78.

about the sentence and he wants to hear it. He has to stand roughly where the Greek listener stands and that means starting from the verb behind the standard translations. *Legein*. To gather to lay together to collect. An older meaning one Aristotle writes over with the speaking-sense and the translations make the word so familiar they hide what it does.

For the listener of the fragment Heidegger reaches for an older German verb *vernehmen* to take in to apprehend to receive. Its modern counterpart is *wissen* to know and *vernehmen* is receptive and *wissen* is acquisitive. An extraordinary civilization of knowledge is built on the second and it is deaf to what the first asks for and it is ours.

Homologeîn. To agree to say the same. It is to let your speaking come into alignment with what the *logos* lays down and assent to a proposition falls short of it. The saying-the-same is a speaking-with and Heidegger's translation comes out strange and the strangeness is deliberate.

Take the sentence into the heart a word at a time. *Ouk emou* not of me not from me not mine. With it the speaker begins by removing thier self. *Tou logou* of the gathering and the genitive functions as source rather than possessive and what is heard comes from the world rather than from the one reporting on it. *Akousantas* having listened. The aorist participle marks a listening already accomplished on which the following verbs depend. *Homologeîn* to say the same to speak in accord. After listening the speaker brings their speech into coincidence with what they have heard. *Hen* one. *Panta* all things. *Einai* to be. Five monosyllables stand in the core of the sentence with no main clause at all and the sentence refuses predication.

The sentence has traveled twenty-five hundred years and what it points to is still there. The man who walks into the temple and puts the book in it means it for a listener he will never meet and this story is written in the same timbre for that listener.

II

APOPHASIS

ON NEGATION

*“The reader should know
that in yes and no
all things consist.”*

— Jacob Boehme

There is a phrase older than almost everything still spoken and it says nothing. Neti neti. Not this not this. Two words and the second repeats the first and between them stands the whole art of approaching what cannot be approached by addition. The sages are not being coy. They have a problem and the phrase is their answer and the problem has not changed in three thousand years. You want to know the deepest thing and every word you reach for makes it one thing among others and the deepest thing is not one thing among others and so every word fails at the moment of contact.

The phrase is the oldest blade of the Advaita Vedanta the teaching that reality is not two. Ask the teacher to name the Self the ground beneath the seer and the seen and no name comes. What comes is a withdrawal. The Self is not this not this. Ask for the positive and the answer is subtraction. Whatever you bring forward is taken back. The body taken back. The breath taken back. The mind that thinks the body and the breath taken back. And the witness who watches the mind and even the watching drawn off the table.

You hear this and you think it is humility and a shrug and a confession that the teacher does not know. It is the opposite. The teacher knows exactly what the phrase does and does it on purpose and it is finer than any answer could be. Say the Self is light and you have made it the kind of thing that contrasts with darkness and the Self does not contrast with anything and contrast requires two and there is only ever the one. Say the Self is bliss and you have made it exclude sorrow and it excludes nothing and to exclude is to stand against and there is nothing for it to stand against. Every predicate is a fence. And the phrase tears the fences down faster than the mind can build them.

Use the phrase rather than admiring it and notice what it does. You sit and you ask what you are. The first answer comes. I am this body. Neti. Not this. The body is something you have and something that changes and something you can observe and

what observes is not what is observed and so the body is not the final answer and you set it down. The next answer comes. I am these thoughts this stream of wanting and fearing and remembering. Neti. Not this. You watch the thoughts and what watches is not the thought because the thought comes and goes and the watching stays and so the thoughts are not it and you set them down too. And then the subtler answers come and they are harder because now you are removing the things you had taken to be most intimately yourself.

I am the one who is aware. Neti. Even that. The moment you say I am the aware one you have made awareness into a property belonging to an owner and the owner is a thought like any other an image of a self standing behind the eyes and that image can be observed too and so it is not the observer and so it falls. This is where most people stop because this is where the floor goes and as long as there is a someone doing the negating the negation has not finished. The phrase is ruthless about this and does not let you keep a self to stand on while you deny everything else and the one who says not this is told not this in turn.

The phrase repeats and the doubling is deliberate. Neti neti. The negation comes twice and the first handles the gross and takes the body and the world with it and the second is aimed at the first. The mind denies the world and congratulates itself and now the denial itself the achievement of having transcended becomes a new this and a subtle object and a position the self stands on. So the phrase comes a second time and removes the remover. Not this either. Not even your renunciation. Not even your knowing that you have renounced. A negation that stops at one pass leaves a residue and the residue is the most dangerous object of all the self that thinks it is free.

Śaṅkara gives the bare phrase a method a thousand years later and the method begins with an error in dim light.

You see a coiled rope in dim light and you take it for a snake and you leap back and your heart pounds and you are in the grip

of a thing that is not there. It has a real effect on a body real fear and real flight and yet there is no snake. There is only ever the rope and the snake is laid on it by a mind working in insufficient light. And the snake is not destroyed by any action. You do not kill it and you do not chase it off. It vanishes the instant the rope is seen as rope. The correcting of the error is the whole of the cure and the error was never anything but a misperception laid over what was always there.³²

This for him is the entire human situation. The rope is the Self pure being and awareness without a second and the snake is the world of separate things and the separate self that moves among them the whole vivid theater of a person in a universe. We do not create the universe by an act. We lay it over the rope the way the mind lays the snake working in insufficient light and mistaking what is for an arrangement of what is not. And the liberation Śaṅkara teaches is not the destruction of the universe. It is the seeing of the rope and the snake of separateness vanishes and nothing is killed to make it vanish. The light comes up and the misperception cannot hold.

And now the method turns and shows its teeth. If the world is laid over the rope then so is every word the scriptures lay on the highest reality and every last one of them. Scripture says the Self is being awareness fullness. Sat cit ānanda. Being consciousness bliss. And Śaṅkara who reveres these scriptures more than his own life turns the method on the scriptures themselves. These words too are superimposition and they are aimed correctly and they are still predicates laid on what has no predicate and so they too must be retracted. The Self is called being to deny that it is nothing and then the word must go because the Self is not a being among beings not an existing thing in the inventory of existing things and even the truest words are scaffolding.

³²The rope and the snake carry Śaṅkara's doctrine of superimposition (adhyāsa), set out in the preamble to his *Brahmasūtra-bhāṣya*. Translation in George Thibaut, *The Vedānta Sūtras* (Oxford, 1890-96).

Here Advaita walks off alone. Every other faith keeps a floor and stops the knife before it reaches the last names. You may deny that God is a body and deny that God changes and deny that God has any edge but you must keep that God is good and keep that God is one and keep that God is. Śaṅkara holds nothing final except the rope and the rope cannot be described and so every word is provisional including the holiest. God's names are themselves a snake laid over the rope useful and aimed right and to be let go when the light comes up. He does not say this to diminish the names. He says it because a name held as final becomes the last and most stubborn object standing between you and what has no name.

So the work needs an instrument fine enough to cut a word away from the wordless without cutting the wordless too and the tradition has one and names it *viveka* and calls it the crest-jewel and the jewel gives the *Vivekacūḍāmaṇi* its title.³³

They call it a sword and not a lamp and the word is chosen with care. A lamp only shows. It throws its light on the real and the unreal and lets you tell them apart and leaves them lying there side by side. The sword does the other thing. It cuts and it severs what has been fused into one false thing. The body and the self are fused and the sword goes between them. The seer and the seen have collapsed into a single muddled experience of being a person in a world and the sword holds the two apart the witness on one side and everything witnessed on the other. And the dividing is the freedom because the bondage was the fusion itself the taking of the seer for the seen. Only a blade can undo a fusion that a thousand lamps would only show more clearly.

But every blade has a hand that holds it and the hand is the seeker and the seeker is the one thing the cutting never reaches. You cut the body and you cut the world and you cut the mind

³³*Vivekacūḍāmaṇi*, the Crest-Jewel of Discrimination, attributed to Śaṅkara; trans. Swami Madhavananda (Calcutta, 1921). The attribution is contested; the sword is not.

that thinks them and you are still standing there at the end with the sword in your grip and the standing is the last thing left and the most invisible. The sword cannot turn on its own hand. And in the twentieth century a man named U.G. Krishnamurti takes the blade and turns it on the hand.

The gentle traditions have something he refuses. They have a method and a path and a sequence of steps and the method consoles even as it works because to be on a path is to have somewhere to stand and somewhere to go. U.G. takes that away. He says any method strengthens the seeker because a method is something the seeker does and the doing reconfirms the doer at every step. The seeker meditating is more of a seeker not less and the seeker practicing *neti neti* reinforces the one who practices and every method feeds the only thing that stands in its way. This is the wall the apophatic path runs into when it is honest all the way down and even negation made into a practice becomes one more thing the self does to perpetuate itself.³⁴

And the seeker walks out of every method still holding one word in the hand and the word is the goal itself and the name for the whole of what the negating was toward and the Greeks see it still gripped there and they go after that too. Pseudo-Dionysius writing under the borrowed name of Paul's Athenian convert has already sent the seeker climbing into the darkness beyond every name. Damascius last head of the Athenian Academy goes further and turns on the last word the climbers keep. Ineffable.³⁵

When we call the One ineffable he says we have already failed because to call something ineffable is to say something about it and to hang a name on the nameless and to make it one more thing that can carry a description. But a name is a saying and so the word ineffable is itself a saying about the unsayable and

³⁴U.G. Krishnamurti, *The Mystique of Enlightenment* (Goa, 1982).

³⁵Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Mystical Theology* Damascius, *De Principiis*, trans. Sara Ahbel-Rappe, *Damascius' Problems and Solutions Concerning First Principles* (Oxford, 2010).

it breaks itself in the speaking. We have not honored the One's transcendence by calling it ineffable. We have violated it and smuggled it back into the realm of things that can have descriptions.

Follow the regress he refuses to stop. We say the highest is ineffable and that says too much so we correct it. It is not even ineffable for ineffable is a name. But now we have said it is not ineffable and that too is a saying about it a second predicate replacing the first and so it must be corrected in turn. It is not the case that it is not ineffable either. And there is no stopping point no level at which the corrections settle into a final true statement because every statement including the statement that no statement is possible is itself a statement and falls under its own verdict. Damascius does not flee this regress. He walks straight into it and reports back from inside it that the endless self-canceling is the only accurate relation thought can have to what is beyond thought. The regress is the answer and he calls it that and he does not flinch.

And still there is someone inside the regress doing the correcting and someone who says it is ineffable and then says it is not even ineffable and the someone never leaves no matter how many times the saying cancels itself. The cold unsaying strips the names off and leaves the stripper standing in the cold holding nothing and shivering and wholly intact. Something has to come for the one who is left. And it comes as love. Ibn 'Arabī carries the negation into love and the Sufis call its consummation *fana* the passing-away of the self.³⁶

He sees more completely than anyone that the unsaying and the union are the same act seen from two sides. The negative theologian strips every name from God thinking to honor God's distance. Ibn 'Arabī sees that the stripping of names is the closing

³⁶Fana, the passing-away of the self in God. For Ibn 'Arabī on the names as veils see William C. Chittick, *The Sufi Path of Knowledge* (Albany, 1989).

of distance because the names are the veil and the predicates that seem to describe God are the forms that hide God by making God into a knowable object and to remove them does not push God further off. It lets God appear as what is always nearest the being of the one who is looking the whole time. Negation does not lead to an absent God beyond all reach. It leads to the discovery that there was never anything but God and that the seeker was the Real seeking itself and that the distance the names try to span is a distance the names have made.

So the warmth of his vision completes the negation instead of softening it. The cold negations of the philosophers strip away every name and leave the seeker standing intact in the bare presence of what cannot be named still a someone facing a nameless something across an unbridgeable distance and the negation of love strips away the seeker too the last name and the final predicate and the one that all the cold negations leave standing. Fana is the negation reaching its own ground and turning at last on the negator and burning off the one who has been doing all the stripping and leaving only the Real in which the seeker is consumed like a moth in the flame it flew toward. This is the fire the whole story has been circling and here at the end it does the one thing the cool methods could not. It takes the one who lit it.

Each figure before him arrives at something the seeker reaches and stands in. Ibn ʿArabī alone takes the stander away and so he is the end and not merely the last. The others lead the seeker to the edge of the self and he leads the seeker over it. You have come closer to this than you think. There are moments when the self thins almost to nothing and you do not notice until afterward. You are lost in work and there is the work and no one doing it. You are caught by something beautiful and for a breath there is only the beauty and no one standing outside it looking. You give yourself so wholly to another person that the line between you goes quiet. Each time the one who watches drops away and each time you come back and call it a lapse and pick the self up

again because you are frightened of what you were without it. The mystics point at exactly these moments and say that is the door and you have walked past it your whole life. What they did on purpose and forever you have done by accident and for a second and the only difference is that they did not flinch and reach back for the self when it started to go.

So this story ends in dissolution as it must because every negation in it reaches toward this and falls short and it has to fall short because a negation is still a saying and the term of negation is the end of saying the passing away of the one who says. Not this not this says the first sage and goes silent. Remove the superimposition says the logician and let the rope be the rope. Cut says the crest-jewel. There is nothing to attain says the man who hates all of them. Climb into the darkness says the false Areopagite. And here at the end Ibn ‘Arabī gathers all of it into a single fire and says pass away. Let the self that has done all this seeking be burned off like a veil and what remains when there is no longer anyone to remain is the only thing that ever was the Real which every negation reaches toward and which is reached only in the disappearance of the one who reaches.

ON ABSENCE

*“I am the silence that is incomprehensible
and the idea whose remembrance is frequent.”*

— Thunder: Perfect Mind

Someone walks out of a city. They have money or they do not and they have a family or none a reputation or its ruins behind them. None of it matters once they cross the last cultivated field and the road gives out and there is only the dry ground ahead and the rock and the long light. They keep walking and at some point they stop and they build a low wall of stones or they find a cave already cut by water that no longer runs and they stay there. They have gone to the desert to be alone. We assume they go there to escape something. They go to be caught.

The ones who do this go out into the deserts of Egypt by the thousand and the word given to every newcomer is the same. Go sit in your cell and your cell will teach you everything.³⁷

We do not believe this can teach anyone anything and our disbelief is exactly what they warn us about. We think a teacher tells you things and that learning is the arrival of new information from outside you. The cell teaches by removal and it takes away the people you would distract yourself with and the tasks you would lose yourself in and the small constant traffic of stimulation you mistake for being alive and when all of it is gone you are left with what was underneath it the whole time which is you restless and frightened and bored and finally if you stay long enough quiet. The cell does not add anything. It subtracts until you are visible.

The aloneness of the cell is not loneliness. Loneliness is the pain of an absence you did not choose the ache of wanting someone who is not there and solitude is the chosen emptiness and the deliberately cleared ground and the room you go into on purpose and shut the door behind you. The lonely one is full of the people who are not there and the solitary is empty and in the emptiness something can finally arrive that the crowd was crowding out. They do not go to the desert to be without God.

³⁷ Abba Moses to a brother seeking a word. *Apophthegmata Patrum*, alphabetical collection, Moses 6; trans. Benedicta Ward, *The Sayings of the Desert Fathers* (Kalamazoo, 1975).

They go to be without everything else so that God has nowhere to hide and neither do they.

A brother asks Abba Poemen what to do about the thoughts that trouble him in the cell and the old man tells him to think of one shut up in a jar with a snake and a scorpion.³⁸ The one does not run. The one cannot run the jar is sealed. The one sits with the venom and outlasts it. That is the cell. You are sealed in with the things that frighten you and there is no exit and the discipline is to stay until they exhaust themselves against the inside of the walls. We hear torture and they hear freedom because the snake and the scorpion are inside them the whole time carried everywhere and the only place they can ever be faced is the one place you cannot get up and walk away from them. The sealed jar is not the prison. The open world was. The jar is where the venom finally has to come out.

Go sit in your cell and your cell will teach you everything. The cell is still there and it is wherever you are when you finally put the world down and do not pick it back up wherever you stay when everything in you is telling you to leave. You will meet the demon there at the middle of the day and you will be sure that this is pointless and that you should be somewhere else. Stay anyway. The thing you are running toward when you run out the door is the thing you came to be free of. Do not feed it. Sit still until it has nothing left to eat. And on the far side of it when the restlessness finally dies and the room goes quiet the desert gives you the only thing it ever had to give. It gives you nothing. That was always the gift.

You can stand in an empty room and feel it. The light comes across a bare floor where the furniture used to be and the sound carries differently with nothing to soften it and the room takes on a strange largeness once it is cleared and the emptiness is not

³⁸The jar with the snake and the scorpion is in the *Apophthegmata* under Poemen; Ward, *Sayings*.

nothing and you can feel it press. People move house and walk back through the rooms they lived in for years now stripped and the rooms undo them small and vast at once with the marks on the walls where the pictures hung. A room is more itself empty than it ever was full and what undoes them is not really the room. It is everything the room held all of it made suddenly visible by being gone.

Gaston Bachelard spends a career on the poetics of lived space and keeps arriving at the emptiness.³⁹ The emptiness he keeps returning to is the inhabited room when the one who inhabits it has stepped out. A room that has never been lived in is merely vacant holding nothing because nothing has happened in it. But the room of someone who has just gone is louder with them than it would be if they were sitting in it. Their chair and the indentation in the cushion and the cup they set down and the particular disorder that is theirs and no one else's speaks them and speaks them louder because they are not there to speak for themselves. This is the emptiness that grief knows and after a death it becomes the most full and most terrible room in the house an absence with more presence in it than the living person ever had.

If God is everywhere and there is no place where God is not and the divine fills all of being completely and without remainder then where is there room for anything else to exist. Where could a world go and where could you go. A jar filled to the brim with water has no room for a stone and the stone can only enter if some of the water is first poured out. And if God is the water and fills everything infinitely and leaves no room anywhere then a single thing that is not God cannot exist and cannot be and has nowhere to stand. There is no room and God's fullness leaves no space for a world. And yet here is a world. So something must

³⁹Gaston Bachelard, *La Poétique de l'espace* (Paris, 1957); trans. Maria Jolas, *The Poetics of Space* (New York, 1964).

have been done to make room for it and something must have been removed.

Isaac Luria is a kabbalist in the hill town of Safed and he lives a short life and writes almost nothing down and what little survives comes through his students. And his answer is built entirely out of absence. Before there is a world there is only God the Ein Sof the Infinite filling all and for a world to come into being God performs an act of contraction and draws in where every other account has the source pour out. God withdraws. God pulls back from a region within and makes a space empty of God's own infinite presence and into that emptied space that vacated room a world can come. The first divine act is not creation but withdrawal.⁴⁰

The word for the withdrawal is *tzimtzum*. Every other account of how the world begins is an account of overflow of emanation of something pouring out from the source of fullness spilling into being and Luria reverses the whole picture. The world begins not when God pours out but when God draws in not by an addition but by a subtraction. Creation is what happens in the hole that God makes by contracting and for anything to exist at all God first makes a region of God empty of God. Absence is not the failure of the divine plan. It is the first move of it the move without which nothing else can happen.

We assume that the presence of God is the good and the absence of God is the lack and the deficiency and the thing to be lamented and overcome. Luria says the absence of God is the gift and the withdrawal and the love and a God who would not withdraw who insisted on filling everything with infinite presence would be a God in whose fullness nothing else could ever live. There would be no world no other no you only the

⁴⁰The *tzimtzum* and the *reshimu* descend from Luria through Chaim Vital's *Etz Chaim*. Gershom Scholem, *Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism* (New York, 1941), seventh lecture. Luria dies at thirty-eight having published nothing.

undifferentiated infinite filling all of being with itself. For there to be anything that is not simply God the Infinite has to step back and make room and open a space where an other can stand. That emptiness in the heart of things the place where God is not is the place where you are. Your existence is housed in a divine withdrawal.

And love we think is an approach a drawing near a closing of the distance between the lover and the beloved and here the first act of the divine love turns the other way. It withdraws. It retreats and it makes distance and God draws back so that there can be a beloved at all. A beloved absorbed into the lover with no distance between them would be only a part of the lover and there would be no love because there would be no two. Love requires distance and an other standing across it and so the first thing love does is make the gap and withdraw far enough that there is room for someone to stand on the other side and be loved. The absence at the start is love's first act the clearing of the space in which everything between two can finally happen.

The Infinite draws back from the cleared space and does not leave it utterly void scoured down to a perfect nothing. Something stays behind. The kabbalists call it the *reshimu* the trace and it is an impression of the light that was there the way a vessel that has held a fragrant oil keeps the scent after the oil is poured out. The emptied space is an absence and it is saturated with the memory of the presence that vacated it and it is a cleared room still faintly charged with what filled it. And into this charged residue the new light comes to begin the making of a world. The withdrawal leaves a pregnant nothing an absence that remembers and holds the trace of what is gone the way the inhabited room holds the one who has just stepped out and the way the desert holds the shape of the water that no longer runs through it.

So when you stand in the emptiness and it frightens you when the silence at the heart of things seems to prove that there

is nothing there the emptiness is exactly what a loving infinite would make if it wanted you to exist. A God who filled everything would leave no room for you and a God who loved you enough to want you real and separate and a someone capable of loving back would have to do the hardest thing and withdraw and go absent from a region so that the region could become yours. In the beginning the Infinite withdrew itself into itself and so made a space in which the worlds could be. You are standing in that space right now. The emptiness around you is not the proof of abandonment. It is the proof of how much room had to be cleared to make a place for you to stand.

Before anyone speaks there is silence and we treat it as nothing and as the mere absence of speech and the blank that words are about to fill and we are so eager to fill it that we cannot bear to leave it alone for more than a moment. A pause in conversation becomes unbearable within seconds and somebody rushes to cover it anybody with anything because the silence feels like a failure and a hole and a thing gone wrong that needs to be fixed by speech. We have it exactly backward. The silence is not the absence of the speech. The speech is the disturbance of the silence. And that disturbance is not always an improvement.

The Greeks know two silences and name the full one *sigē*.⁴¹ You can watch the difference in any real conversation. There is the pause where someone has run out of things to say and is uncomfortable scrambling for anything to fill the silence and everyone in the room feels the pressure of it and someone rushes to end it. And then rarely there is the other pause the one that opens when something true has just been said and a real thing has landed and there is nothing to add and the silence that follows is not empty but full and everyone recognizes it as the right response and knows that speech would ruin it. Nobody rushes

⁴¹*Sigē*, the full silence, stands as a divine name in the Valentinian systems: Irenaeus, *Adversus Haereses* I.1, where Silence is the consort of the unnameable Depth.

to fill that one and everyone knows without being told that the silence is the continuation of the meaning and not its interruption and that to speak now would be to break something. We still have access to that silence occasionally in the presence of the dead and in the moment after music ends and in the rare conversation that goes deep enough to reach it. It is the same silence the Greeks called *sigē* the full one the one that holds and that we still fall into it sometimes proves the thing is not lost only buried under so much noise that we almost never reach it.

Go back to the one in the cell who has outlasted the snake and the scorpion and sits now in the quiet that is left. Nothing has been added. The walls are the same and the light crosses the same floor and no vision has come and no voice and no answer. Only the noise is gone and under the noise there was this the whole time. The one who can sit in it without reaching to fill it has reached the end of the long work the desert sets. And what is carried out of the cell cannot be named or shown. It is a tolerance for the empty and a steadiness in the lack and a way of standing in a bare room or a bare hour without needing it to be filled. The one who has it is unafraid of the very thing the rest of us organize our whole lives to avoid.

The desert gives nothing and that is its gift and the Infinite withdraws and that is its love and the silence holds the place from which every word is born. Each absence does work no presence can do. We are taught to want only the fullness and everywhere this story has looked the lack is where the living thing happens.

ON DEATH

*“God is not averse to deceit
in a just cause.”*

— Aeschylus

At the very end of the Republic after Plato has built his perfect city in words and weighed justice against injustice and argued about the right ordering of a soul he does something that has embarrassed his admirers ever since. He stops arguing and tells a story. A man dies on a battlefield and lies among the corpses for ten days and is carried home to be burned and on the twelfth day already laid on the funeral pyre he sits up alive and tells what he saw on the other side.

Er watches the souls led before a heap of lives spread out on the ground and hears the herald announce the terms.

There is no daimon who will get you by lot he says. You shall choose your own daimon. The responsibility lies with the one who chooses. God is blameless.⁴²

That sentence is the spine of everything. Plato has built an entire afterlife whose single function is to throw the weight of your destiny back onto you. There is no fate handed down from above that you can blame and no cruel god arranging your suffering and no luck. There are lives spread out on the ground lives of tyrants and beggars and athletes and exiles and lives of beasts and human lives and you walk among them and you pick one up and whatever you pick becomes your necessity. Your choice is free and everything after it is bound.

After the choosing comes the binding. Each soul has chosen and is led to the three Fates and they ratify the choice and spin it tight and make it irreversible. And then they are all taken to the plain of Lethe through a terrible scorching heat with no tree and no green thing and they camp at evening beside the river of Forgetfulness and no vessel can hold its water. And every soul is required to drink. Those without the sense to ration themselves drink more than the measure and the more a soul drinks the more

⁴²Plato, *Republic* X, 614b-621d, the myth of Er. The herald's proclamation: 617e.

it forgets until everything is gone every memory of the meadow and the judges and the thousand years and the choosing.

So you do not remember. According to Plato you stood in that meadow and watched the heap of lives and chose the one you are living now with your own hand and then you drank the river dry and forgot you had ever chosen anything. You walk through your life convinced it was handed to you and that your circumstances are someone else's doing and the whole time the truth is that you picked this.

For all of time the dead stayed dead. A wall stood between the living and the dead and the few who swore they had crossed it and come back belonged to myth and to scripture and everyone knew to hear them that way. And then we learned to start a stopped heart again and the wall grew a door.

The paddles and the crash cart and the whole apparatus of the emergency ward do the one thing no temple or mystery ever could. They bring the dead back by the thousand and sit them up in hospital beds and hand them their voices and let them talk. Their hearts have stopped. Their breathing has stopped. In many cases their brains have gone flat. And then they are hauled back across the line and a certain fraction of them come back with a story.

A cardiologist named Pim van Lommel runs the cardiology ward at a hospital in the Netherlands and he keeps hearing the story. Patients he has himself resuscitated describe the same impossible things when they are well enough to speak. They have floated above their own bodies. They have watched the resuscitation from the ceiling. They have passed through a darkness toward a light. They have met dead relatives. They have felt a peace so complete that being dragged back into the body feels like a punishment. And van Lommel a working clinician with no mystical agenda decides to stop dismissing it and to start studying it.

So he does the one thing a scientist can do with something he cannot dismiss. He counts. Three hundred forty-four cardiac arrest patients and roughly one in five come back with clear ordered conscious experience out of the very minutes the brain shows nothing at all.⁴³

Then there are the cases that break the explanations. A patient van Lommel describes comes into the hospital in deep coma and cyanotic and with no heartbeat and the resuscitation team removes his dentures to intubate him and puts them in a drawer of a crash cart. The man is revived after a long effort and moved to intensive care. More than a week later still on the ward he sees the nurse who was part of the resuscitation and tells her you know where my teeth are you put them in the drawer of that cart. He has watched it from above. He describes the room and the people and the cart and the very actions of the team from a period when he is deeply comatose with no heartbeat. There is no way for him to have seen any of it through his eyes. His eyes are not working and he is clinically dead.

And they come back with the review. In the middle of the passage the whole life stands up at once every scene of it simultaneous and sorted and the one going through it feels every act from both sides the kindness as the one who received it and the cruelty as the one it landed on. Nobody instructs them to weigh their lives. The weighing is simply there the way the meadow was simply there and the lives spread on the ground. Plato sets the judgment after death in a story and the cardiology ward hears it reported as an event with the monitors still running. And they lose the fear. The ones who go deepest come back altered for the rest of their lives and it shows in how they die when the real death comes and they go curious.

⁴³Pim van Lommel and others, Near-death experience in survivors of cardiac arrest: a prospective study in the Netherlands, *The Lancet* 358 (2001), pp. 2039-45. The dentures case is reported there. The fuller argument: van Lommel, *Consciousness Beyond Life* (New York, 2010).

Van Lommel draws the only conclusion the data will let him draw and draws it as a scientist knowing exactly how it will be received. If clear structured consciousness occurs during a period of no brain function then the brain does not produce consciousness. It is more like a receiver an organ that tunes and narrows a consciousness that does not begin in it and does not depend on it. When the brain fails the tuning gives way and consciousness is released from the narrow band and this is why these people report awareness vaster and clearer than anything ordinary life allowed. The brain does not generate the light. The brain dims it.

The chemistry has a candidate for the door. Rick Strassman injects volunteers with dimethyltryptamine in a hospital room in New Mexico and they leave their bodies and pass through a door and meet presences and come back reporting the country the dying report.⁴⁴ Researchers at Imperial College London give the molecule to volunteers and lay the reports beside the near-death accounts and the two sets of testimony run close to interchangeable the tunnel and the light and the presence and the peace and the certainty stronger than any waking certainty that what they saw was more real than this room. The molecule is not exotic and it is in the human body already and nobody is sure what it is doing there. The skeptic says the dying brain squirts its own key into its own lock and the vision is chemistry and the vision ends there. The other reading asks what the key was cut for and a key implies a lock and a lock implies a door and a door implies a somewhere. In the seconds after the heart stops the brain does not wind down like a clock. It flares once hard and ordered and nobody knows whether that is the machinery failing or the door opening.

⁴⁴Rick Strassman, *DMT: The Spirit Molecule* (Rochester, Vt., 2000), from the New Mexico injection studies of 1990-95. The Imperial College comparison: Christopher Timmermann and others, DMT models the near-death experience, *Frontiers in Psychology* 9 (2018).

None of this needs a laboratory to be said. A century before the crash cart an American poet walks the wards with the same report and no instruments at all. He has no monitors and no molecule and no journal to publish in and he has the grass and the grass is enough. Walt Whitman looks at death and calls the bluff. The smallest sprout shows there is really no death he writes and if ever there was it led forward life and does not wait at the end to arrest it.⁴⁵ He has watched the dying in the war hospitals of Washington holding their hands through the last hour boys from both armies and he of all people is not talking himself out of grief. He writes what the grass shows him. Matter does not leave the world and motion does not leave the world and the body unknits and is taken up and handed on and the one you are looking for is under your bootsoles and growing. To die is different from what any one supposed and luckier. He does not argue it. He announces it the way you announce weather you are standing in and the announcement has outlived every argument made against it.

Put the reports side by side. The cardiac ward and the molecule and the poet and the man on the pyre agree on the strange part. Nobody comes back reporting an ending and every one of them reports a door and a difficulty at the door and a country past it and the ones who stood deepest in it come back with the fear burned off them. What every witness sees is a change of state violent and total and survived and the survival is the report. No witness has ever seen the wall. Every witness reports a door.

The ancients do more than map the passage. They build a rite that takes the living through it.

For nearly two thousand years the most important religious event in the ancient world was a secret and the secret was kept. Year after year and century after century tens of thousands of

⁴⁵Walt Whitman, *Song of Myself*, sections 6 and 52, in *Leaves of Grass*. The war hospitals are in *Specimen Days* (Philadelphia, 1882).

people walk the road from Athens to a small town called Eleusis and go down into a great hall in darkness and see something there and come out changed and not one of them ever tells what they see.⁴⁶

The public frame was the myth of Demeter and Persephone the daughter taken into death and returned and the rite's outline is known the fasting and the procession and the dark hall and the great light.

That is the shape of it even if the content stays hidden. In ritual you undergo the thing the myth describes. You go down into the dark into a representation of death and you come back up into the light and you rehearse your own death and your own survival of it. You do not hear that death is not the end. You do it. You die a small ritual death in the Telesterion and come out the other side still yourself and that doing that direct passage through a staged death is what no argument can give and what takes the fear away. You cannot argue a person out of the fear of death. But you can walk them through a death and out again in the dark by torchlight until the body itself learns that there is a coming-out.

They go down into the dark fasting and exhausted and frightened following the torches into the great hall and in the blackness they pass through their own death and then the fire blazes up and the thing is shown and they understand all at once without words what the mother and the daughter have always meant that what goes down into the dark comes back that the seed is buried and rises that they too will be buried and will rise and they walk out into the dawn over the sea and they are never afraid again. Happy is the one who has seen these things. We have not seen them. That is the whole of our situation said as plainly as it can be said.

⁴⁶The rite ran at Eleusis for near two millennia and kept its secret. The beatitude: Homeric Hymn to Demeter 480. Karl Kerényi, *Eleusis* (New York, 1967); Walter Burkert, *Ancient Mystery Cults* (Cambridge, Mass., 1987).

The old world treats dying as a skill and we treat it as a malfunction. We have arranged death to happen behind a curtain in a clean room and the dying person is sedated past the point where any word could reach them surrounded by machines and strangers and not by a voice saying their name and telling them what comes next. The ones who built the hall at Eleusis would look at our deathbeds with horror. We are sending people through the door asleep.

We kept the myths and lost the rite. We have the story of the passage in a hundred forms and we can read Er and read the *Lancet* and read the poet and still not one of us has been walked through a death and brought back out while we were still strong enough to learn it. The knowing stays in the head where it does the least good. The initiates did not believe the passage. They had made it. And when the true death came the body already knew the way because it had gone down into the dark once by torchlight and come back up and the fear had nothing left to grip.

The man on the pyre gets the last word because he got the first. Er is sent back Plato says as a messenger to the living and everything since is the message arriving again and again in whatever tongue the age can hear. The meadow becomes a ward and the judges become a review and the herald becomes a cardiologist with a clipboard and the message does not change. You will put down the body the way you put down a tool when the work is done and what you are does not go down with it. Every witness in this story is one messenger with many faces and the message is not for the dying. The dying are about to know. It is for you who still have time to live as if it is true or to live as if it is not and that choice is the only judgment there is.

III

POESIS

ON FORM

*“All the rivers run into the sea;
yet the sea is not full;
unto the place from whence the rivers come,
thither they return again.”*

— Ecclesiastes 1:7

They rode on and the sun in the east flushed pale streaks of light and then a deeper run of color like blood seeping up in sudden reaches flaring planewise and where the earth drained up into the sky at the edge of creation the top of the sun rose out of nothing like the head of a great red phallus.⁴⁷ McCarthy builds his sentences out of a single joint and the joint is the word and. He lays clause against clause against clause with that one word between them and almost nothing else and none of the small hinges that tell you which thing rules and which serves. He gives you the things in a row. The men ride and the sun rises and the blood runs in the sky and the dust comes up off the horses and the dead lie in the road. Each thing has the same weight as the thing before it and the horse and the murder and the weather all stand level and that leveling is the whole vision. In McCarthy's world they do stand level. A sun does not care which thing it shines on. He writes sentences that do not care either and the not-caring is the most frightening thing in him.

Notice what the flatness does to horror. A writer subordinates and tells you how to feel. The sentence says that tragically the child died or that despite their efforts the men were lost and the adverb and the concession do your grieving for you. McCarthy will not spare you. He sets the death in the row of things with the same and that joins the sunrise to the breakfast and the death arrives without warning and without comment and without the cushion of a syntax that ranks it above the breakfast. Horror is in the leveling. A child is killed and the sentence does not slow down and the prose treats the killing the way the desert treats it as one more event in the long indifferent series. The reader supplies the scream the syntax refuses and it is louder than any the writer could write. Read the sentence about the sun again and watch what your own voice does. Nothing in the words tells you

⁴⁷Cormac McCarthy, *Blood Meridian* (New York, 1985), chap. 2. The sentence is quoted whole; it cannot be paraphrased and that is the argument.

the dawn is dreadful and the dread arrives anyway because the sentence walks at the pace of the riders and never once looks at you and a thing that will not look at you is more frightening than a thing that stares. You lean in toward prose that withholds the way you lean toward a man who speaks quietly and the leaning is the style doing its work.

The chain is already halfway to a spell. Read McCarthy aloud and the and comes back like a footfall and the sentence walks on it and what walks arrives in country that argument never reaches. One word recurring is the oldest instrument there is. Before the drum there is the heartbeat and before the litany there is the wave and the body is built around returns it did not choose and trusts them the way it trusts nothing that happens once. A form that repeats gets in under the doorsill of attention. The mind is made to notice the new and the recurring goes past it unquestioned the way the clock on the wall goes unheard until it stops. McCarthy hides the return inside a sentence that seems to be going somewhere and Kingsley slows it down and holds it up and lets you watch it come back.

Peter Kingsley says the thing and then says it again and then says it again. An analytic mind processes a thing once and files it and moves on hungry for the next thing. Feed it new information and it stays awake and in charge sorting and judging. Repetition starves it. The same phrase comes again and then again and the mind has nothing new to file and begins to relax its grip the way a sentry relaxes when nothing happens on watch hour after hour. And under that relaxing grip something else can come up. Kingsley repeats not because he has run out of ways to say a thing. He wants the saying to stop being about the thing and start working on you the way a drumbeat works on a body and the way a wave works on a shore by recurrence and by return.⁴⁸ You

⁴⁸Peter Kingsley, *In the Dark Places of Wisdom* (Inverness, Calif., 1999) and *Reality* (Inverness, Calif., 2003), where the repetitions are the teaching.

can feel the grip loosen in the reading. The first time the phrase comes you take its meaning and the second time you check the meaning against the first and the third time there is nothing left to check and the words start to move through you the way water moves through a place it has already shaped. The meaning survives every return. The guard does not.

In Reality he spends six hundred pages on two poems and hardly a page of it is explanation. The prose circles Parmenides and circles Empedocles and comes back and back to the same few fragments the way the tide comes back to the same rocks and every return wears the reader a little more open. He is building the state the poems were written for. The scholars translate the fragments and the fragments stay shut and Kingsley repeats them until they give. By the time he sets What is, is in front of you for the last time you are no longer reading a proposition out of the fifth century. You are standing where the goddess put it and the words of a dead language in a broken poem open under your feet like the floor of the cave. His form infects theirs. The spell he casts is the vestibule and the poems are the room and the whole labor of the incantation is to carry you through their door in the condition the room requires.

What the spell knows the whole art knows. Form carries what content cannot and the shape of language holds what the words cannot say and the reason is already written in this story. Logos is the gathering that lets the river be the river and physis is the self-emergence of what arises and a made form is the two of them built small. A form is a pattern that produces its own next moment. The and of the chain calls for the next one and the phrase of the spell calls for its own return and the reader's mind runs the pattern and the running is the feeling. Experience inside a medium arises where the shape propagates itself the way the world arises where physis opens and what you feel when a sentence carries you is the small self-effulgence of a world being made at the pace of your own reading. Form is the cycle that

turns and in turning gives off the light you read by. Once in a century a maker tries to build the wheel that turns everything at once.

Borges spends his life trying to write a single sentence that will hold everything. He never says so and he does not have to. Read him and you feel the pressure of it on every page the way someone digging in one spot betrays what they are after by how deep they go. He distrusts the novel because the novel spreads. He writes stories of ten pages that others would pad into five hundred and the brevity comes from exactness. Find the right small figure and you can fold the whole world into it and hand it across whole.

His name for that point is the Aleph. In the story a man goes down into a cellar in a house on a doomed street in Buenos Aires and lies on the floor in the dark and looks at a certain spot under the nineteenth step and he sees there a small iridescent sphere two or three centimeters across in which every point of the universe appears at once and nothing overlaps and nothing is dimmed and every thing is whole. He sees the populous sea. He sees a copy of the first English translation of Pliny. He sees the circulation of his own dark blood. He sees his own face and his own bowels. He sees the letter that a dead woman wrote obscene and unbelievable and he reads it. He sees the Aleph from every angle and in the Aleph the earth and in the earth the Aleph again the figure turning back into itself. Then he stands up and the man whose cellar it is bores him with talk and the moment is gone and the house is torn down for an expansion of a café.⁴⁹

That is the form and the form does the telling. A point that contains all points cannot be described in sequence and sequence is the one thing it does not have. Borges knows this and says it plainly inside the story. The eyes see everything at once and what

⁴⁹Jorge Luis Borges, *El Aleph* (1945), collected in *El Aleph* (Buenos Aires, 1949); trans. Andrew Hurley, *Collected Fictions* (New York, 1998).

they see is simultaneous. What he sets down he must set down one word after another and the gap between the two is the whole grief of writing. So he does the only honest thing and gives you a list. He piles the disparate things one against another with no rank the sea and a book and a face and a corpse and a letter and the flatness does the work no explanation could.

A finite thing holds an infinite thing the way a sonnet holds love and the way a sphere two centimeters across holds the populous sea.

The Aleph holds everything and belongs to nothing. That is its terror and the reason the story ends in a demolition. A form that contains the world owes the world nothing and sits in its cellar complete. The older makers want the opposite. They want the made thing bound to what it shows the way the half of a broken ring is bound to its other half and for that a form cannot merely contain. It has to belong. There is an older and humbler way of holding and it works by kinship and one man gives his years to it. Ananda Kentish Coomaraswamy spends them on a single broken coin.

The word itself carries the teaching. The Greek behind symbol is a broken thing made whole. A symbolon is a coin or a tile snapped in two between two parties so that each keeps half. Brought together again they fit along the jagged break and prove the bond and identify the bearer. The symbol is the half that calls for its other half a fragment that fits a reality it was broken from. The two were once one thing and fit along a line no forgery can copy and the fit is real built into the break. The sign is whole in itself and points elsewhere by agreement. Coomaraswamy keeps returning to the old meaning and the old meaning holds the whole of it. The broken token knows its missing half and calls to it across the break.⁵⁰

⁵⁰Ananda K. Coomaraswamy, *The Interpretation of Symbols*, in *Coomaraswamy: Selected Papers*, ed. Roger Lipsey (Princeton, 1977). The symbolon as broken token is the classical usage.

You have carried half a token yourself. A song belongs to someone and the someone is gone and the song comes on in a store and the whole person is suddenly in the room. Signs point and this does not point. It fits. A jagged edge in you meets the jagged edge it was broken from and while the verse lasts the two halves are one thing again. That is the symbol working and nobody taught you to read it because it is not reading. It is recognition.

A century of classrooms shows what happens when the difference is forgotten. Generations of students have been asked what the whale stands for and the question is the allegorical question and it ruins the book. The whale does not stand for anything. It participates in everything it touches in the unknowable and in God and in nature's indifference and in the void and in the white blankness that is the absence of all color and the presence of all of them and none of these is the answer. There is no answer. There is only the whale the form holding all of it at once in a way no concept can. Ask what the whale means and you have already failed. Read the whale and dwell in it and let the form work on you and you receive what the book has to give and it is not a meaning you could have been told instead. Melville builds a symbol in the old strong sense without the theory Coomaraswamy would give him. The proof is that it has resisted a century and a half of decoding and stands there still unsolved alive.⁵¹

The whale holds its infinite by standing in it and some forms hold by moving. Plotinus writes prose that climbs and he leads the reader up and up and at the summit at the One the prose arrives at a silence for the One cannot be said and the honest climb ends where speech ends at the edge of the sayable looking out at what no word will cross. The false sublime ends loud and

⁵¹Herman Melville, *Moby-Dick* (New York, 1851); the whiteness of the whale is chap. 42.

mistakes the summit for a place to shout the largest words. The true anagoge climbs to the edge of language and then falls still. The prose grows quieter as it rises. A reader carried all the way up arrives at the brink where the words give out and the giving-out is the arrival.⁵²

One figure is older than every maker in this story and every scribe who built to last reached for it. The poems of the oldest scriptures go out and come back the end rhyming with the beginning and the middle standing as the hinge on which the whole thing turns. The Greeks name it chiasma for the letter chi the crossing of two lines. It is the and of the chain bent into a circle and the return of the spell made whole and a reader who feels the end answer the beginning is released for a moment from the tyranny of the line.

The makers die. Borges goes blind long before he goes and McCarthy dies in a house in Santa Fe with the desert sun still coming up out of nothing on his pages and the scroll of Heraclitus is ash somewhere under Ephesus. The forms do not die. The sentence about the dawn breaks over whoever opens the book and the spell still slows the blood after its speaker is under the ground and the broken poem of Parmenides carries a goddess in fragments across twenty-five centuries of dropped and burned and forgotten libraries to say what is, is in a room she has never seen. Content is what a maker knows and the knowing dies with the maker. Form is how the knowing travels after.

⁵²Plotinus, *Enneads* VI.9, On the Good or the One, the treatise that ends where speech does.

ON MYTH

*“Think of a spring that has no source outside itself;
it gives itself to all the rivers,
yet is never exhausted by what they take,
but stays always integrally as it is.”*

— Plotinus

You are small when somebody first tells you how everything began. All that is or ever will be is pressed into a point with no size and the point is not sitting in any darkness and it is not waiting through any night for place has not happened yet and before has not happened yet and then it opens. You take this in the way you take in every story told to you at that age which is to say completely and without the least trouble and the strangest part is that the physicists take it much the same way. It is the one creation story you were raised inside and it came to you the way every myth has ever come to anyone. Somebody told it.

And notice the shape the telling keeps. First a nothing that is not quite nothing and then the arising and then the separations. In the first three minutes the world cooks the makings of every star and then for four hundred thousand years it is a fog so hot and so bright that light cannot cross it and every part of it is blinding and none of it can be seen and then the fog clears and the light comes loose from the matter and goes free.⁵³ The light is divorced from the dark. And that first light is still arriving and you have seen it. Turn an old television between stations and a measure of the snow hissing on the screen is the light of the first morning still coming down.⁵⁴ Matter gathers out of the glare and the hydrogen drifts together and kindles and the first stars burn and the names come later the way names always do. Every people that has ever waked on this earth has told the beginning of the world and told it in this shape and our tellers tell it with instruments and the shape holds. A nothing that was not nothing and an opening and the separations and the world standing up out of the light one thing at a time.

⁵³The standard telling: Steven Weinberg, *The First Three Minutes* (New York, 1977). The fog clears at recombination, some four hundred thousand years in.

⁵⁴The first light is the cosmic microwave background, found by Penzias and Wilson in 1965. Roughly one percent of the static on an untuned analog television is that light.

Even the name of our beginning is a story about stories. The man who hates the idea is the one who names it. Fred Hoyle believes in a universe that was always here and he goes on the radio reaching for a phrase to make the rival picture sound ridiculous and calls it a big bang and the mockery outlives the mocker and the theory wears the insult as its name to this day. That is how myths are made. Somebody tells and somebody counters and the best phrase wins whether its maker meant it to or not.

And you cannot picture any of it. A point with no size and no place around it defeats every image you try to hang on it and the fog with no outside and the light that is everywhere at once come no easier and the tellers with the instruments will tell you plainly that they cannot picture it either. They calculate what none of them can see. The story exceeds its tellers in the telling and every true story of beginning does and the first tellers knew this and bowed to it and went on telling. A beginning you could picture would be a beginning inside the world and the one thing a beginning of the world cannot be is inside it.

The arising is in you and every morning you wake into it. There is a moment before the day assembles itself before you remember your name and your debts and the thing you said last night that you should not have said and in that moment the day has not begun and neither have you and you return there every night when sleep takes you down past the place where dreams are. The mystics call it many things and most get it wrong by naming it too quickly but the experience underneath the names is the same opening the story points at. Consciousness begins as an opening and the world rushes in and the rush feels like creation because it is.

Watch a thought form. Sit still and watch one come. You cannot. By the time your attention arrives it is already there and already a thought and already furnished. You never catch it arriving. The silence before the word is a nothing that is not nothing for the thought is already on its way out of it. That ungraspable

instant is the cosmogony happening in you right now over and over and faster than attention. The world is made continuously in you in the half-second before each thing you think you already understood.

The tellers who first told the beginning of the world watched the same arising you watch in yourself and they did what tellers do. They told it. Raising a world is the oldest commission in the craft and before the wars and before the heroes someone has to raise the world the wars will be fought in. A myth of beginning is the art of storytelling doing its first job and doing it in the open. Somebody says the nothing and says the opening and says the things that come up out of it in their order and whoever says them has begun to make a world out of words and everything a storyteller will ever do is already in that first saying.

Every teller alive repeats the act and none of them had to be taught it. The theater before the first frame and the page before the first line and the fire before the first word all hold the same waiting and the waiting is older than any of them. Then the voice moves. Once upon a time is a separating. It cuts a time out of time and sets it apart and the room divides into a here where you sit and a there where it happens. There was a man cuts one man out of the many and a road cuts one road out of all roads and every sentence after is another separation and another naming and the named things stand. A world assembles in the order the words arrive and it is made of nothing else.

And the place the voice moves into is you. The teller brings the word and you bring everything the word will be made of. Whatever stands up in a story comes out of your own life out of every road you have walked and every face you have feared and loved and the teller has never seen any of it and does not need to. The word goes down into you and what it finds there answers. No two listeners hear the same story for no two bring the same life and a story heard again after twenty years has changed because you have.

You do this every day and call it nothing. Tell anyone what happened to you this morning and watch your own mouth work. The morning had no beginning. It poured in on you the way mornings do with no edges and no order and no plot. And you cut one. You say so I was standing in the kitchen and with six words you have divided a time out of time and raised a ground and set a figure on it and the person across the table is already living there. You separate and you name and you order and out of the heap of a lived morning a small world stands that was not there before you spoke. Every anecdote is a cosmogony the size of a minute. You have been performing the first act of the world since you learned to talk.

You know the act from the other side too. You have looked up from a book and found the room strange because you have been elsewhere and there was no elsewhere. There was ink. A desert rises out of sentences with the sun coming up on it out of nothing and there is no desert anywhere on earth but in the saying and still the ground holds and the light crosses it and you squint. Whole worlds are raised out of words by makers long dead for readers they will never meet and the worlds hold. That is the power the myths of beginning are about and the tellers of those myths knew where they got it. A people that says the world was spoken is a people that has watched worlds come out of mouths.

And every night you outdo yourself. Sleep takes you down past the place where dreams are and then brings you up into them and you build whole worlds without meaning to with a weather and a cast and a geography and grief and none of it exists and all of it holds while you are in it. Nobody writes these cosmogonies down. By breakfast the worlds are gone the way the first worlds went and you have been a maker all night and you remember almost none of it. Worlds come up out of you whether you ask them to or not. Making worlds is the oldest thing you do and the craft only trains what the sleep already knows.

Peoples who never crossed each other's paths wake up telling the same story. First the opening and then the ground lifting out of it and then the separations the light from the dark and the above from the below and the names coming down on things like frost. Nobody convened them. The story is the same because the arising is the same and every one of these peoples watched it happen not once at the foot of time but every morning in the first moment before the day assembles and every night falling past the place where dreams are. A cosmogony is a report on the near inside written large across the sky and the far past is only its address. Stand at a window before dawn and run the whole of it yourself. The dark without edges and the first pale separating along the rooftops and the things stepping out of it one by one and taking their names back. Every sunrise is the oldest text there is and the peoples who told cosmogonies were not speculating. They were reading. Run it again at the other end of the day and watch the names go back into the dark one by one the fence first and then the hills and then the hand in front of you and the unmaking is as gentle as the making and the world ends every night without violence and is there again by morning. Nothing about the first morning is over.

The beginning has been told for as long as there have been mouths and it has never once been told the same way twice. Every people tells it again with what it has. The ones with fire tell it with fire and the ones with rivers tell it with water and we have instruments so we tell it with instruments and the instruments do not make ours the last telling any more than the fire made theirs the first. The story is alive the way anything is alive. It is being handed on and changing hands changes it.

The last myth is the end of the world and even our tellers tell one. The stars burn through their fuel and go out one by one and the galaxies slide apart faster than their light can cross and the dark comes back that was here first. Some of the tellers stop there and some say the world falls back in on itself and is pressed once

more into the point with no size and opens once more and runs the whole story again. Nobody knows and the not knowing does not stop the telling. An end of the world is told in the shape of a story for a story is the only shape we have ever had that is large enough to hold one.

Every story you have ever finished has put you out at the same door. The last page turns and the world that held you unmakes itself behind you and you sit for a moment in the hollow it leaves with the room coming back around you one thing at a time. Tellers have always known that an ending is a little apocalypse and the old tellers close the circle with the end reaching back to touch the beginning.

You know this from your own endings. You have ended things and relationships and jobs and whole chapters of yourself and you have noticed that no ending is ever only an ending and the death of one thing is the clearing of the ground for another. Even grief the purest experience of ending we have even grief is a making. Slowly and terribly it makes a self that can live with the loss and it builds a new world over what the loss broke open and the building is the beginning again. You have lived the whole arc of this story in a single bereavement. The end tore you open. The tear was not empty. Something new against your will began to grow.

Some night a child will ask you where everything came from. Children ask it the way they ask for water. It comes at the end of the day when the light is going and the guard is down and the question is enormous and the voice asking it is small. And you will hear yourself begin. All that is was once pressed into a point with no size and there was nothing around the point for place had not happened yet and then it opened and the light came loose and the stars caught and the ground gathered under what would one day be your feet. You will hear your own childhood in your mouth as you say it. Somebody said this over you once in

a room you can no longer picture and the saying kept and now it is yours.

The child will take it in completely and without the least trouble and lie there watching it happen the way you did. And the child will want it again. Another night the question will come again and this time it will come as an order. Tell the one about the point. And you will tell it and if you wander from the words you used before the child will stop you and set you right for children know before anyone teaches them that a told world must be kept in its own words and every one of them enforces this and none of them can say why. You were the same. Some night deep in your smallness somebody varied the telling and you caught it and made them go back. The beginning has been guarded that way for as long as there have been beginnings by small listeners holding their tellers to the telling.

And some night after that the harder question will come. What was there before the point. And you will say nobody knows and you will feel the floor of the story hold under you as you say it for nobody knows is part of the telling and has always been part of the telling and the child will nod in the dark because the answer is true and a true nobody knows satisfies in a way no invented answer ever has.

And the child will grow and stand some night in a doorway of a room you will never see with the light going and a small voice asking where everything came from and your words will come out of a mouth that is not yours with your pauses still in them. The world will be made again that night out of nothing but a voice and made again after that and after that in rooms and years no teller will ever count. That is the whole craft and the whole myth.

ON CINEMA

“Turn my eyes away from worthless things.”

— Psalm 119:37

You come in out of the daylight and the lobby takes your ticket and the doors close behind you and the lights go down and the talk dies with the lights. The religions that wanted this state built the same way every time in the dark and in caves and in windowless rooms and the cinema rebuilt their architecture and never knew it. The lobby is the antechamber and the darkening is the threshold and the sealing of the doors is the sealing of the space and the bright screen in the dark is the fire the cave was always organized around. You have walked into a cave ten thousand years of practice prepared and you believe you have bought an evening's entertainment.

And the film starts and your body begins to leave you. Blocking speaks to diegetic sound and the two intermingle with each cut and you seep into a state of hypnosis. You blink fifteen to twenty times a minute in ordinary waking life and held by a film the rate collapses to three or four and the body forgets its own maintenance for something larger has taken the reins of attention. Tamami Nakano finds that we do not merely blink less in the dark. We blink together. The lids hold shut through the charged image and they release in unison at the cut and the editor conducts a chamber of involuntary eyes and the audience breathes on the editor's count.⁵⁵ Uri Hasson names the phenomenon neurocinematics. A film of sufficient command drives a crowd of separate nervous systems into near-identical activity and strangers think the same thought at the same frame.⁵⁶ And each blink lives out a small death. The cut falls and the eye closes and for an instant the self is not there to pretend and the watcher briefly does not exist. The oldest religious technologies wanted exactly this. They wanted the separate self dissolved into a single

⁵⁵Tamami Nakano and others, Synchronization of spontaneous eyeblinks while viewing video stories, *Proceedings of the Royal Society B* 276 (2009), pp. 3635-44.

⁵⁶Uri Hasson and others, Neurocinematics: the neuroscience of film, *Projections* 2 (2008), pp. 1-26.

moving rhythm and they built it with drums and chant and the dark of a cave and we built it with a lamp and a shutter and a strip of images and we sell tickets to it and we tell ourselves we are only watching. We are closer to being moved through.

The word for what has happened to you in the seat is hypnosis and not the stage trick with the watch on the chain but the thing under the trick. Attention narrows to a single channel and the body hands its own governance to whatever holds the channel and a hypnotist gets there by taking things away and removes the competing claims on your attention one by one until one voice is left and the only voice in a mind becomes the mind. Cinema does this to a thousand people at a time in a dark room and does it better. Via negativa at twenty-four frames a second. The film empties you of everything else and the emptiness is the medium the one rhythm moves through.

Kurosawa Kiyoshi knows it and puts the hypnotist inside the film. Cure gives him a flickering lighter and a flat exhausted voice and he drifts from stranger to stranger asking who they are and asking it again without threat and the asking hollows them out until they kill. You watch the hypnotist hypnotize and the watching hypnotizes and the film does to you what the drifter does to them and it never once raises its voice.

The emptied watcher is ready to receive and the films that go deepest choose that moment to hold something back. Most haunted films never show you a ghost. The ghost is breathed in through the photography and the locked-off cameras and the austere composition and the decay. The place a person used to stand stays in the frame long after they have walked out of it. Schrader calls the manner transcendental style and it works by subtraction. It takes the movement and the incident and the music and the coverage and the reassurance out of everything until a patient surface is left. The surface cracks into what he calls stasis a frame so emptied of event it implies something past the

edge of the visible.⁵⁷

The camera inherits the move from the contemplative traditions and never knows what it has taken. Mystics want to speak about God and learn that the surest way to lie about God is to describe God and every attribute they assign shrinks God to the size of the attribute. So they go the other way. God is not light. Our light is small. God is not good. Our good is partial. They peel the names off one by one until nothing is left to say and in that nothing the thing they are after has room to appear. Cinema looks like the most affirmative of the arts and shows you everything and at its highest runs the same procedure through a lens and arrives at what it refuses to show.

We have nearly lost the patience this asks. The contemporary image is engineered against stillness and it moves and you cannot rest and it cuts and you cannot dwell and it scores every moment and tells you how to feel and it promises that nothing is withheld and the frame contains all there is and you are safe inside the shown. The haunted image breaks the promise and tells you by its stillness that something is kept back. We built a culture of total visibility that cannot let a face be still for three seconds and still we flinch when a film refuses to reassure us and the flinch is the proof that the image touched the thing we spend our money not to touch.

A photograph is already a death mask. The light that bounces off a body at one instant will never bounce that way again and the photograph keeps it. Film keeps twenty-four of these a second. It is a machine for embalming time. Every film is a haunting and a procession of the no-longer-present moves as if present and the films that know it never need to invent a spectre. They hold a face long enough and you feel it is already gone and the light left that skin years ago and reaches you now like the light of a

⁵⁷Paul Schrader, *Transcendental Style in Film: Ozu, Bresson, Dreyer* (Berkeley, 1972; reissued with a new introduction, Oakland, 2018).

dead star. The empty room is the most loaded image in cinema and the cheap jump scare the emptiest. A jump scare shows you the thing. It fills the frame with a body and a face and a monster and in the filling it kills it. What was frightening was never the monster. It was the room before the monster came and the breath the room held while it was not yet filled.

Stasis is paid for in duration. The film spends real seconds of your irreplaceable life on purpose and the arrival is purchased and never handed over and a frame becomes transcendental only after it has made you wait the waiting wearing down your appetite for incident until you look at what is there instead of what is happening. And when the incident is gone what stands there is mortality. The lit window at dusk. The road that goes on after the car has left it. The cup on the table that will outlast the hand that set it down. Death is folded into every ordinary surface and we spend our lives editing it out of our attention and the held frame puts it back. The style shows you the surface and then it holds and in the holding the surface fails and through the failure for one second you see.

You know the withheld thing from your own nights. A sound wakes you at three in the morning and the house is silent by the time you are awake enough to listen and you lie there with your heart going asking the dark what it was. No answer ever comes and the not knowing keeps you listening longer than any answer would. A named sound is a closed case and the unnamed one owns the night.

Apichatpong Weerasethakul takes even the image away and builds *Memoria* on a sound with no source which is his way of asking whether anything has one. The sound wakes Jessica before dawn in Bogotá a concussion with no cause and the car alarms in the lot below answer it one by one and fall quiet and no one else in the film will ever hear it. Seth Horowitz finds we hear twenty to a hundred times faster than we see and the ear is the old alarm that works in the dark and around corners and

while we sleep and the bang is in her body long before her eye has anything to find.⁵⁸ The whole film is her trying to follow it back to a source. She tells the sound engineer Hernán it is like a ball of concrete dropped down a metal well ringed with seawater and they build it up out of a sound library until it is close yet it is never the thing itself. So she carries it out of the city and up into the hills to a second Hernán a fisherman who has never left and remembers everything and never dreams and who lies back and stops like a machine. The sound she hears is in him too and has been down in the ground. It is a memory older than anyone a signal laid down before there was a self to receive it and Jessica is not its subject but its antenna. Apichatpong gives her no image for it and no explanation and no relief only the thing itself moving through her felt and never shown and the film ends where apophysis ends at the one truth that will not survive being turned into an image.

And what a sound can do a person can do. Think of the ones you love. You hold a handful of their years and the rest is dark to you and the love does not wait for the missing decades. It runs on what is withheld the way dread does. A character in a film is the same mercy run backward and the less the film hands you the more of yourself you spend filling the figure and the spending is the caring.

The Coens carry the refusal into the cut itself and spend half of *No Country for Old Men* hiding Llewelyn Moss. He speaks in fragments and he moves like a man rehearsing something he already survived and the story declines to say what. What we know of him we know through Carla Jean. He teases and she answers and the love runs under the deadpan and never once surfaces as a declaration. The marriage is shown moving and never told. We do not know who he is and we do not know

⁵⁸Seth S. Horowitz, *The Universal Sense: How Hearing Shapes the Mind* (New York, 2012).

why we should care and we watch him anyway. Twenty years of history and the film never names Vietnam until a bounty hunter says it first one veteran recognizing another across a Mexican hospital bed and once more a man makes him name his truth. He served in the 12th Infantry from the middle of 1966 to the middle of 1968 and the border guard waves him through on it. Twenty years extracted from a film that has spent its entire run time refusing to declare its hero's identity.

At exactly the sixtieth minute the lock cylinder in the Eagle Pass hotel door blows in from a cattle gun and tears into his chest and the war comes back through the body instead of the mouth. The man who was forced to jump from the window enters back in through the way he came. He ran and hid and listened at walls and now he stands in the open street and fires and the hinge turns every character in the film and Chigurh is made human through the loss of his blood and the instrument of fate is made flesh in a single exchange. And when the death of Moss comes the film declines even that. He is killed between one cut and the next and the sheriff arrives in El Paso to the blood of a man who sought to return to his wife and the case full of money already gone. The withholding runs to the end and past it. McCarthy's God is the same. It does not appear and it does not provide an answer. The withholding is its presence. Ed Tom's father carries fire ahead in the dark and he does not turn around and then Bell wakes up.

The dream is a prayer and the film never says so. An old man wants his father to be ahead of him in the dark making a fire against the cold and he wakes before he can reach him and the film ends there on a wanting it refuses to satisfy. Every deep film leaves you holding one. And there is a film that asks what would happen if the wanting could be answered.

Tarkovsky pours the whole of it into a landscape and lets it soak. In *Stalker* a guide takes two men across a poisoned zone toward a room that answers prayer and the crossing is slow and wet and the camera holds the water and the grass and the backs

of their heads until the dread has soaked into everything and nothing has happened at all. At the door the men understand the Room. It grants what one truly wants not what one asks for. Prayer is what you ask and desire is what you are and the Room ignores the asking and reads the wanting and the men cannot face being read. A man they call Porcupine has walked in before them praying for his dead brother and come out rich and hanged himself. They do not open the door. They go back the way they came and forget the way behind them. Only the Stalker weeps. He wants nothing behind the door and he does not forget the crossing and his burden rests in memory. Tarkovsky never provides an answer to prayer. The door stays closed and the film ends and no one learns what the Room holds or whether it holds anything. Only this much is shown. Men carried across a land poisoned by their longing.⁵⁹

The Room reads what you are instead of what you say and the dark room you are sitting in does the same. Two hours of surrender and your defenses down and the film reaching into you with both hands. And what it reaches oldest is what was formed first. Children of distant fathers carry a phantom pain and it aches where a limb never grew. In cinema the absent father is felt before he is seen. He is gone and taken from the frame by death or distance or his own turning away. Heinz Kohut finds that the child of a distant father builds a father inside and because the figure never draws close enough to disappoint it stays flawless.⁶⁰ The camera holds the father at that pitch in the frame yet never near enough to become ordinary. Deus absconditus. Near enough to long for and never near enough to meet. Paris, Texas

⁵⁹ Andrei Tarkovsky, *Stalker* (Mosfilm, 1979), after the Strugatsky brothers' *Roadside Picnic*. Tarkovsky's own poetics: *Sculpting in Time*, trans. Kitty Hunter-Blair (London, 1986).

⁶⁰ Heinz Kohut, *The Analysis of the Self* (New York, 1971), on the idealized parent imago.

banishes him and Benny's Video makes him a coward and O Sangue kills him and each leaves the same distance behind.

The child erects an idealized figure in the place where the real one failed to stand and keeps it there polished and immense and it is built out of need and not out of a real man and it has no flaws. Flaws come from contact and there was no contact. The tragedy is that it works. The inner father consoles and the consolation costs the child every real man he will ever meet.

Cinema knows this distance in its bones. Its screen is a wall of light you cannot cross and the people on it are present and unreachable at once and that is the pitch the idealized father lives at.

Travis walks out of the desert at the start of *Paris, Texas* mute and burnt. He has erased himself and the whole film is the slow recovery of why. In the peep show Travis talks to Jane through one-way glass telephone to telephone able to see her and speak to her and never touch her and the scene is the whole architecture of the absent father made into a literal room. The glass is the screen. He gives her back the son and goes because he has understood that he is more use to the boy as an absence the boy can idealize than as a presence the boy would have to forgive.

None of these films gives you the reconciliation scene because the thing the child longs for was never the real man but the figure his absence made and the figure cannot be met only mourned. The understanding scene is the great lie of the paternal melodrama the moment where the distance collapses into comprehension and the wound is retroactively healed by a revelation and it is a lie because the wound is not a misunderstanding. It is the distance itself. A son who learns his father loved him has learned a fact about a person and he has not dislodged the figure his longing built unreachable because it was made out of absence and absence cannot be filled by information.

This is the *deus absconditus* on screen the hidden God of the negative theologians carried down into a family and that God

does not hide out of cruelty. God hides because presence would be the end of faith a God you could see and touch reduced to the size of your seeing. So God withdraws and leaves the soul reaching and the reaching is the spiritual life. Kohut's distant father is the same structure run at human scale.

And we are looking up. A screen is above us and larger than us and we sit in the dark beneath it the way a child sits beneath the height of a father taking it in and unable to reach it idealizing by the very angle of the looking. You do not have to have had a distant father to feel these films. You only have to have sat in the dark looking up at something you could not reach which is to say you only have to have watched a film at all.

Longing outlives the film because the films install the distance in you the way the father installs it in the child and the cinema did not depict the wound from outside. It opened the one you already had the one the angle of every screen has been pressing on since the first time you sat in the dark.

Then the lights come up. You walk out through the lobby into the shock of the ordinary evening and the cars and the phones and the noise take you back and something keeps walking with you the way a dream does in the first minute after waking. You have been used by a voice in the dark and you are glad of it and there is no guarantee the dark room will always be there to do it.

The fear of the new medium is the oldest tradition in language. When writing comes Thamus tells Theuth it will create forgetfulness in the souls of the learners and when print comes Hugo has the archdeacon lift his eyes from the book to the cathedral and say this will kill that and when television comes the man sent to regulate it calls it a vast wasteland.⁶¹ Three fears thousands of years apart and now the machines write and the

⁶¹The three fears: Plato, *Phaedrus* 274e-275b, Thamus to Theuth; Victor Hugo, *Notre-Dame de Paris* (1831), book V, chap. 2, this will kill that; Newton N. Minow, Television and the Public Interest, address to the National Association of Broadcasters, 9 May 1961.

fear has my own trade in its mouth. Language will die its endless death and it will be a beautiful one and there is nothing that can be done. Cinema is the latest jar and the screen is its seal and something is in it that the death of every medium so far has failed to kill.

I have spent this whole story in the dark beside you pointing at what others made and one story is left and it is mine. I have held it back the way the films I love hold back what matters most. There is no screen in it and no director and no dark room and it is still cinema to me and by the end you will recognize why. It has the desert and the dread and the withheld thing and the voice that reaches across a distance it has no reason to cross. It happened in daylight on a western.

During the production of *Yellowstone: 1883* I nearly died one morning at five-thirty driving eighty to work as an eight point buck broke into a full sprint across a single lane Southbound highway in Paducah, Texas and leapt and caught the hood of my Mercedes midair and came apart across it.

I wasn't the only one who came close to death during those six months. That season the deer and the highways took their turns with all of us and we mostly didn't talk about it as far as I knew.

I was working as an electrician on my first show wet behind the ears and greener than all hell too immature to sustain relationships in my personal life and too stubborn to part ways with what I thought I knew to the point that I kept to myself.

After we spent a few weeks throwing footballs in Montana Tim McGraw consoled me after hearing from other crew members what had happened. He didn't know me. He used his voice on me anyway.

It took four near death experiences before I learned to use mine.

Thank you Tim.



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